

Covenant of Varkaar

The Covenant

The Covenant of Varkaar is not a kingdom, not an empire, not a dominion. It has no hereditary rulers, no divine mandate, no claims of superiority over other peoples. What it has instead is a promise and a pact. Five provinces are bound by mutual defense, shared economic interests, and a common identity forged over four thousand years of protecting travelers, enforcing contracts, and keeping the Ring Road open.

The promise is a formal one: the Articles of Bordered, in which the ancient protectors of the great migration documented their oath to protect the sentient folk of the Saskan Lands from danger and oppression, to guard to the borders of the Lands, and to watch over and protect travelers throughout the Lands. The pact is a looser. The regions that grew up around the town of Bordered hold to the Articles, to one degree or another, but more importantly they contribute to and support the organizations that make the Articles work. Together they are called the Covenant of Varkaar, the league of protectors.

The Covenant is unique among the major powers of the Saskan Lands. Where the Fatunik Dominion demands submission to religious authority and the Empafarasi maintain their mysterious isolation, the Varkaar provinces practice something closer to confederation, a voluntary alliance of regions that maintain substantial autonomy while pooling resources for common defense and economic advantage.

It works. Mostly. When it doesn't, the cracks show quickly.

Bordered Province

The heart of Varkaar power and home of the Articles, Bordered

encompasses the capital city and some rich agricultural lands around it, built along the northern tributaries of the Pavan River. Second only to Beshqauhoek in population and wealth, Borted is a manufacturing powerhouse. It provides arms, farming implements, hand tools and more and it is a major business and financial center. The Varkaar Council meets here in an opulent palace. The Varkaar Union coordinates guild activities from another massive hall. The great warehouses of the Free Hostelrys Cooperative Council, also located in Borted town, store grain, metals, textiles, and trade goods from across the Saskan Lands.

Borted's wealth creates resentment. The other Covenant provinces know that Borted profits from their labor. Liganalupán's ore, Sallofòl's fine craftsmanship, and Oknott's furs and timber all flow through the warehouses and counting houses of Borted. They accept this because Borted provides credit, markets, and diplomatic weight in a way they could never manage on their own. But the acceptance is grudging, especially in lean years.

The province of Borted speaks a unique variety of northeastern Eibar similar to that spoken in the nearby Fatunik province of Borda Woods. Folks from both provinces, despite their radically different settings, are referred to as Bordali due to their accent. In much the same way that the Fatunik Dominion does, Borted considers itself the primary cultural heir to the great Migration. The leaders of the Covenant of Varkaar maintain close, if occasionally tense, relations with the Fatunik Authority. Borted merchants trade extensively with Fatunik territories and Borted banks hold a great deal of debt for merchants from the Fatunik towns. This economic entanglement shapes Borted policy in ways the other Varkaar provinces sometimes find troubling.

Sallofòl Province

Smaller, quieter, and often overlooked in the great song cycles of the Varkaar folk, Sallofòl specializes in precision craftsmanship. The province is known for ceremonial weapons. The ornate basher sticks carried by Tagabant officers, the etched daggers worn by Báhkar on

formal occasions, the inlaid shields displayed in guild halls -- all are the product of Sallofól fine crafts. Sallofól workshops also produce fine furniture, musical instruments, and decorative metalwork.

This is a province of artisans, not soldiers or merchants. Sallofól sends fewer recruits to the Varkaar Arms than any other province in the Covenant. Its economy depends entirely on Bordered markets and wealthy buyers from across the Saskan Lands and the province maintains good relations with everyone because everyone wants their goods. The joke in Bordered is that Sallofól has no politics, only commissions. The joke in Sallofól is that Bordered has no taste, only money. Both jokes contain truth. From the perspective of the much larger rural provinces, there is little to distinguish Bordered from Sallofól.

Liganalupán Province

The mines of Liganalupán supply much of the metal that flows through Bordered's forges and onto Bordered's markets. Iron, copper, tin, and some silver are extracted from shafts that reach deep into the western mountains, worked by miners whose families have held the same claims for generations. Liganalupán is proud, tough, and a good deal poorer than Bordered. The ore flows out; much of the wealth stays in Bordered. Miners' cooperatives negotiate prices with Bordered buyers and usually lose. The province maintains its own militia, much smaller than the Varkaar Arms and with nothing like the reputation of the elite Báhkar units. They are less well-equipped, but fiercely loyal to local interests. When the Varkaar Council speaks of unity, Liganalupán hears pay your dues and keep digging.

The relationship with neighboring Eelan is complicated. Both are mining provinces. Both resent Bordered's middleman profits. But despite tensions Liganalupán is fully integrated into the Covenant system, subject to the authority of the Varkaar Council and the decisions of the Cann of Bordered, while Eelan fiercely protects its independence. Some Liganalupán miners see this as Eelan getting a better deal, Varkaar protection without Varkaar obligations. Others see it as Eelan's weakness, their inability to fully commit to the very

Articles that protect them.

Oknott Province

The northern frontier. Harsh winters, dense forests, scattered settlements connected by old logging roads and newer mining tracks. Oknott shares a long, poorly-defined border with the hostile Krunkinotto and Wesshewen territories. Folk here grow up hard, suspicious of outsiders, and loyal to kin.

Oknott supplies timber, furs, and a large stream of recruits to the Varkaar Arms. The province supplies more Varkaar soldiers and more elite Báhkar than anywhere else in the Covenant provinces. For broodkins with more courage than prospects, signing on with the Varkaar offers steady pay, respect, and a way out of the northern cold.

The province speaks a distinct dialect of Eibar, sings raunchy songs that make Fatuniks blush, and maintains an wary watch on the northern approaches. Oknott patrols have long reported strange sightings along the frontier with the high Krunkinotto mountains. Shadowy twisted shapes in the deep forest, tracks that shouldn't exist, entire hunting camps found abandoned with meals still on the table. The Varkaar Council hears these reports and files them away. The Oknott town of Moak is one of the most heavily militarized settlements in the Saskan Lands. They have been a stronghold against Wesshewen invaders for generation upon generation.

Oknott remembers who takes their warnings seriously and who doesn't.

Eelan Province (Protected Status)

Eelan is not a member of the Covenant of Varkaar but accepts enhanced protection under the Articles of Bordered. This distinction matters. Exactly what it means is a topic of frequent debate in Eelan town, in Bordered and in Beshqauhoek and elsewhere.

After the Time of Fire, when Tagabant forces withdrew under threat

of Varkaar intervention, the Eelani accepted protection but refused integration into the Covenant when it was offered. They maintain their own governance structures, their own mining operations, their own trade agreements. The Varkaar Council has no authority over Eelani internal affairs. Varkaar Arms patrol the approaches to Eelan and are free to cross through the mountainous region, where there are a number of well-appointed Varkaar Inns, but they are not permitted to create permanent camps within the province itself.

Eelan receives military deterrence against external threats, access to Varkaar trade networks, and non-voting representation at certain Council sessions. Eelan does not provide taxes to the Council treasury or a quota of troops to the Varkaar Arms, nor does it promise to submit to Council jurisdiction in internal disputes. The Eelani Miners Association does provide discounts on its deliveries to Bored and Sallofól based buyers and there is a steady, if small, stream of Eelani volunteers for the Varkaar Arms.

This arrangement worked well enough when Eelan desperately needed protection and Bored wanted to deny the Fatunik Dominion a strategic prize. Centuries later, with new generations in power and old grudges fading, the arrangement feels increasingly unstable. The Eelani see Bored as cautious to the point of cowardice. When Grand Tagabant Tonedor Rumpet shockingly executed two Báhkar in Beshqauhoek for heresy, Bored issued formal protests and continued business as usual. The Eelani expected fury, threats, perhaps even military action. What they saw was diplomatic notes.

From the Eelani perspective, if Bored won't defend its own, can they rely on it to defend Eelan if and when Rumpet turns his attention westward? You will hear miners arguing that it might be better to cultivate ties with the Empafarasi...

The Covenant of Varkaar

While the Covenant of Varkaar and the Fatunik Dominion are similar in the sense that both are formal alliances between provinces, the contrasts between them are stark and deliberate.

The Fatunik Dominion operates on religious authority flowing downward from the Grand Tagabant, his loyal Council of Scriveners and the scribes and other officials who report to them. Provincial Fatunik governors and leaders, even those who maintain a degree of autonomy from the Center, serve at the pleasure of the Fatunik Authority in Beshquahoek. Taxes, tithes, and tributes flow to the Center. Although some issues are overlooked in the interest of keeping funds flowing, dissent is heresy. Period. Unity is enforced via Watchers, Tagabant enforcers and unified ritual.

The Covenant of Varkaar functions through negotiated agreement. The Varkaar Council sets policy for matters affecting all provinces including defense, foreign relations, and standards for trade and coinage. Individual provinces handle their own internal governance, maintain their own local militias, and collect their own revenues. When disputes arise between provinces, they're settled through Council mediation or, occasionally, through carefully limited feuds that everyone pretends aren't happening.

This decentralization means the members of the Covenant cannot move quickly in a unified fashion, whereas a Dominion governor can mobilize troops with a single order, as long as it is approved by the Central command. The Varkaar Council must debate, negotiate, build consensus among provinces with competing interests. By the time the Council agrees on action, the crisis may have already resolved itself, or worsened beyond remedy.

The advantage is that the Covenant is resilient. When the Dominion suffers a succession crisis or a failed campaign or a natural disaster, anything that looks like the Center might not hold, then the entire structure trembles. When one Varkaar province faces hardship, the others provide support, even if grudgingly, because they know their turn will come to need assistance and protection. The Book of Heliohlan, the ancient founding text of Fatunik ideology, whose meaning is difficult to ascertain clearly, has been interpreted as a command to obey Fatune's directives, as promulgated by the Fatunik Authority. The Articles of Bordered, on the other hands, are written in language anybody can understand and clearly state basic principles of dignity, mutual respect and the need to protect each other.

The disadvantage is that the Covenant members can be slow, reactive, and as we have seen recently, vulnerable to a determined centralized power that is willing to act decisively.

Historical Development

The Varkaar identity traces back to the Great Migration, four thousand years ago. While the Empafarasi scouted ahead when the walkers fled the dying lands, the Varkaar protected the great columns of walkers. The mounted guardians ranged ahead and behind. They fought off raiders. They kept the desperate and the dying from overwhelming the march.

After the arrival, when the Saskan Lands were divided and settled, the Varkaar recommitted themselves via the Articles of Bordered. They had horses and other mounts, as well as well-crafted organization and a reputation for competence. Early settlements hired them to protect trade routes. Merchant consortiums paid them to guard caravans. Over centuries, this professional class, already joined together by clear set of principles, evolved into a political entity.

The formal confederation, the Covenant of the Varkaar, emerged gradually, province by province. Bordered and Sallofòl formed the first alliance, an economic marriage between manufacturers and artisans that remains the heart of the regional alliance. Liganalupán joined when raiders from the Krunkinotto began attacking mining camps. Oknott likewise sought protection against invasions from the north. Eelan's protected status came last, much later, after the traumatic Time of Fire.

There was no single founding moment, no grand constitutional congress. Just a slow accretion of agreements, obligations, and shared interests that hardened into political structure.

Current Tensions

The confederation is showing cracks. Economic disparities grow

wider. Bordered controls finance, manufacturing, and trade. The other provinces provide raw materials and labor. Profits concentrate in the capital while resentment concentrates in the periphery. Military priorities diverge as well. Oknott wants more resources devoted to northern defenses, especially against whatever is stirring in the Krunkinotto. Liganalupán wants protection from the Maken as well. Eelan wants Bordered to stand firm against Rumpet's provocations. Bordered wants to avoid expensive wars that might disrupt profitable trade.

Eelan's drift toward High Weir threatens the entire balance. If the most militarily significant protected territory abandons Varkaar protection for Empafarasi backing, what message does that send? Will Liganalupán go next?

The aggressive politics being pursued by the New Fatunik Authority is forcing choices no one wants to make. After the execution of Henqu and Iohane, two celebrated Báhkar of high reputation, Bordered's measured response satisfied no one. Too weak for those who wanted confrontation, too provocative for those who wanted accommodation. The careful diplomatic ambiguity that has served the Covenant for centuries feels increasingly like paralysis.

The Covenant of Varkaar faces a test. Not of strength. The Varkaar Arms remains formidable. There is still little question about who would succeed in a direct confrontation between them and the Tagabant. It is more a problem of will and unity. Can these provinces with divergent interests, including one territory with one foot out the door, act decisively if and when circumstances demand it? Or will the confederation fracture under pressure, each province seeking its own accommodation with rising powers?

The Varkaar of Bordered built their reputation on reliability, on keeping the roads open, on enforcing agreements and protecting civilization. That reputation is their greatest asset. It's also what they stand to lose if they cannot hold together when it matters most.

The Great Ring Road

Stand on the ancient paving stones outside Ingar and look east toward Rutónik. The road before you has been walked for two thousand years. The stone you stand on was laid in the third century after the arrival, when the first Fatunik pilgrims carved prayers into the foundation layers. Beneath that stone lies packed earth from earlier paths, trodden by the original settlers fleeing the dying lands.

Run your hand along the kilometer markers and you'll feel layer upon layer of carved symbols: Fatunik suns, Varkaar oxen, Kahila forest signs, Terpin geometric proofs, even occasional rabbit paw-prints left by unknown hands. Each generation added their marks without erasing what came before.

This is the Great Ring Road. Not a single construction but an accumulation, not a unified vision but a compromise between dozens of communities across two millennia. It binds the Saskan Lands together more surely than any government, any military force, any shared belief.

Without the Ring, there is no trade. Without trade, there is no surplus. Without surplus, there is only survival and starvation. The Ring Road is life itself, made tangible in stone and earth. And while many of the provinces have deep ties to the Ring, the Covenant of Varkaar has tied its core identity to Ring more closely than has any other.

What It Is

The Ring Road forms an irregular circuit connecting the major population centers of the Saskan Lands. Following it clockwise from Pavanoa...

The northern arc follows the Pavan River valley, through the Fatunik

Dominion heartland: Pavanoa → Ingar → Rutónik → Khaliro → Turno → Qurol. The western arc climbs into the western highlands, skirting Empafarasi territories, passing through contested zones: Qurol → Eelan → Barból. The southern arc runs through the boundless Settan agricultural lands and into the Runes of Bye: Barból → Brokily → Byenung. The eastern arc curves along coastal regions and through the Outer Lands: Byenung → Morilly → Selaron → Ríkila, and returns, completing the circuit skirting just past Kahila territories: Ríkila → Pavanoa.

The total circuit is approximately 3,000 kilometers, varying slightly by route choices and seasonal detours around flooded sections or damaged bridges. Every major town on the Ring connects to secondary roads branching toward smaller settlements, mines, agricultural communes, and remote provinces. But these tributary roads are rougher, less maintained, more dangerous. The Ring itself is the artery. Everything else is capillary.

The First Paths: Survival Routes

When the settlers arrived at Ingar, having emerged from the long hiatus underground after the catastrophe they had nothing. No infrastructure, no maps of this strange land, no certainty they would survive the first winter. What they had was desperate need to spread out, find resources, and establish settlements before population concentrated in ways the fragile ecosystem couldn't support.

The first paths were literal foot trails. It was the route scouts took from Ingar toward Rutónik's river ford, the track traders walked to reach Blubar's fishing communities, the pilgrim path from to the sacred sites near what would become Juuj. These weren't engineered. They were trampled into existence by hundreds of feet walking the same routes repeatedly because those routes offered the best combination of water access, defensible camping spots, and distance from dangerous terrain.

In those early centuries, no one imagined that some of these trails would become a great road. They were just the ways between places, maintained by the people who used them, varying by season as floods or landslides forced detours. Certain routes proved more reliable than others. Certain paths became preferred. And where people walk

repeatedly, eventually someone decides to improve the walking.

The Articles of Bordered: From Protection to Purpose

By the third century after arrival, banditry had become a serious problem. Trade routes that worked when settlements cooperated became targets when communities fractured under resource stress. Nascent merchant caravans needed protection. Wealthier travelers started paying for armed escorts. Individual settlements maintained guards for their immediate territories but couldn't patrol the routes between towns.

The Varkaar Arms emerged to address this need. Initially just mounted guardians protecting specific caravans for hire, they gradually organized into something larger. Different Varkaar guards began coordinating, sharing intelligence about bandit movements, establishing standard practices for patrol circuits. Representatives from multiple companies met in Bordered, then a remote frontier town of perhaps 2,000 people and formalized what became known as the Articles of Bordered.

The core agreement:

- Varkaar units would patrol designated routes on regular circuits
- Towns along these routes would provide way stations, stabling, and supplies
- Merchants using protected routes would pay fees to support patrol operations
- Varkaar would answer to their own representative councils rather than local warlords
- The guardians had a duty to protect and respect all travelers

This wasn't yet a road system. It was a protection network overlaying existing paths. But once the Varkaar committed armed and mounted troops to regular patrols, they had strong incentive to improve the routes they patrolled. Hard-packed earth is easier to ride than muddy trails. Clear sight-lines help spot ambushes. The Varkaar organizations began making small improvements: clearing brush, marking dangerous sections, creating emergency caches. These cumulative efforts, repeated over decades, began transforming trails

into roads.

The Northern Expansion: Engineering Begins

As agricultural productivity improved slightly in the fourth and fifth centuries, when the Pollination Guilds were just beginning their technical innovations, populations grew. Trade expanded. The need for reliable transport routes intensified. This period saw the first intentional road construction rather than organic trail development.

The Bordered-Qurol segment, although now it is not considered part of the Ring, was the first Road in the Saskan Lands to feature actual engineering. Varkaar engineers, who were learning techniques from Terpin scholars who were documenting the ancient ruins found in the areas called Juukal and the Runes of Bye, designed roadbeds with foundation layers of large stones; middle layers of gravel for drainage; then top surfaces of packed earth or, in wealthy sections, fitted stone paving. Ditches were dug along both sides for water runoff and the road itself given a cambered surface so rainwater flowed off rather than pooling.

This wasn't altruistic. Bordered was emerging as a commercial power and needed reliable routes to export manufactured goods. The investment in road quality paid returns in increased trade volume.

Around the same period, the segment connecting Khaliro town, then just a growing market village, to the growing northern network was improved. This was politically complex because it meant crossing territories where different communities held authority. The Varkaar negotiated agreements allowing road construction through disputed lands in exchange for guarantees of patrol protection.

By the sixth century after the arrival., you could travel from Bordered through Qurol to Khaliro and on toward Ingar on roads that were maintained, marked, and protected. The Ring was far from being completed, and nobody at that point called it a Ring, but a substantial arc of it existed and was in regular use.

The Southern Arc: Mysticism Meets Commerce

The southern sections developed differently, reflecting the unique

cultural developments in Barból and the Settan lands. Barból emerged in the seventh century from post-war mysticism and a conscious rejection of northern-style military organization. The Barból approach to roads was spiritual. It was believed that paths should facilitate pilgrimage, contemplation, and harmony with landscape.

They Early Barból road-builders created something distinct. They wanted routes that curved to follow natural contours rather than cutting straight lines and rest stations designed for meditation and ritual, not just quartering guard patrols. They introduced the integration of sacred groves and water sources along the route as well as installations of stone carvings, steles and prayer towers at intervals.

This drove the northern Varkaar a bit mad. Efficient patrol routes are straight. Curves add distance and reduce sight-lines. But the Barból communities insisted, and travelers loved it. The southern arc became known for its beauty and spiritual atmosphere even while the managers of the northern segments continued to prioritize function over aesthetics.

As Dauni and Terpin scholars and artisans began moving into the southwestern regions, they contributed engineering sophistication to the southern road projects. The Terpin in particular brought knowledge of hydraulics, bridge construction, and long-term planning. The bridges built in this era spanning the rivers feeding into the Pavan, crossing the marshlands near what would become Terpinol and Scatterling, used principles that wouldn't be deployed in the northern provinces for a few more centuries. Arched stone structures with properly calculated load distributions, built to last. And indeed, several are still in use nearly a thousand years later.

Barból to Byenung: This segment, built over the course of 150 turns in the 9th and 10th centuries after the arrival, showcased what became possible when mystical Barból aesthetics combined with Terpin engineering and Varkaar pragmatism. Arguably the most beautiful section of the entire Ring Road, it featured stone paving of exceptional quality, regular way stations with proper inns and public gardens, bridge architecture that's both functional and artistic and, interestingly, integration with the emerging canal systems that started in Byenung and begun to spread in every direction.

The great Bye-Bar Waterway, connecting the Great Lake to the Bay of Bar near Wildwind was constructed during the period. It never really lived up to its promise, suffering from no end of technical and management problems. The Night Hall continues to debate its strengths and weaknesses to this day.

The Golden Age: Completion and Consolidation

By the twelfth century after the arrival, the vision of a complete Ring Road connecting all major settlements seemed achievable. Large sections existed. What remained was linking them into a continuous circuit.

The Aran Canal was completed around the middle of the 12th century. This magnificent engineering project connected Barból to Terpinol via a navigable waterway. While obviously not part of the Ring Road, it transformed the southern lands by providing faster transport to and from Terpinol. Heavy goods and passengers could now ship by barge rather than the long road, which could be brutal in the summer heat. The Barból-Terpinol canal and road system function as complementary infrastructure.

Final Connections

The segments requiring the most effort were those linking Byenung through Morilly to Selaron, dealing with marshy terrain, volcanic activity and a series of complex engineering and political problems, not least of which was working with the autocratic House of Moballeq. Finally, closing the gap between Ríkila and Pavanoa skirting just around the edge of Kahilakol territories required additional sensitive political negotiation as much as engineering.

By the middle of the 14th century after the arrival of the great huum migration in the Saskan Lands., for the first time you could travel a continuous circuit touching every major population center without leaving maintained, patrolled roads. The completion of the Ring was celebrated across the Saskan Lands. The Ring Road became a symbol of what cooperation could achieve. For a brief period, maybe fifty years, there was optimism. Trade flourished. Cultural exchange accelerated. The Wildwind Festival in the Ny Lands became accessible to visitors from across the continent. The Covenant of

Varkaar was proclaimed, joining together the four provinces settled by descendants of the Varkaar, the mounted protectors of the great migration, under an oath to uphold an expanded version of the Articles of Bordered.

Some say that was the apex of Saskan civilization.

Decline and Disruption

The optimism didn't last.

Around the start of the 15th century after the arrival, a series of conflicts disrupted the Ring, culminating in the Eelani-Fatunik War that devastated the western arc from Qurol to Barból. The Kahila conflict, which had been percolating for centuries, had already made the eastern sections dangerous. Competing authorities fought for over tighter control of the profitable segments.

The Ring Road didn't collapse entirely, but along with the devastation in the west, sections fell into disrepair. Bridges went unmaintained. Pavement cracked without being fixed. Bandits operated with impunity where patrols had withdrawn. Some sections were deliberately damaged. Ríkila, in one of its recurrent rebellions against Fatunik authority, tore up paving stones near the town to slow Tagabant troop movements. Centuries later, that had started as a temporary defensive measure became permanent neglect after the rebellion succeeded.

The Varkaar maintained what they could, but political fracturing meant losing exclusive control over some parts of the Ring. The Road remained conceptually important, but practically speaking, travel times increased, danger rose, and trade contracted.

Patchy Revival

The past four centuries have seen gradual restoration. As political situations stabilized, communities recognized that maintaining the Ring Road served everyone's interests.

The current state is patchwork. Well-maintained sections include: the Bordered- Qurol Road, still not considered part of the Ring itself; the stretch from Byenung to Morilly to Selaron, maintained via the

modern Runik-Mobalbesq alliance; and Barból-Brokily, kept in good shape when Settan trade is good. The roads inside the Fatunik Dominion are kept in fairly good shape as well. The poorer sections are: those near the outskirts of Eelan, never fully recovered from the Time of Fire and often overgrown; on the outskirts of Brokily heading towards Byenung, which is marsh, has less traffic and no clear authority maintaining it; and right around Ríkila town, where deliberate neglect has occurred as a political statement.

One bit of irony is that the segment passing through rebellious Ríkila was once among the finest road construction in the entire circuit but is now among the worst. The same revolutionary spirit that liberated the town from Dominion control resists investing in infrastructure that is seen as serving Varkaar or Fatunik interests.

Walking the Ring Road, you experience two millennia of building techniques, aesthetic preferences, and practical compromises. From Ingar to Rutónik, the road remembers its origins. In places you can see the oldest construction: massive foundation stones laid by the first settlers, fitted without mortar through sheer labor and determination. The stones are worn smooth by countless feet, hooves, and cart wheels. Grooves mark where wagon axles ran. You can trace the exact path traders preferred by following the deepest wear. Between the stones, later generations added smaller fill rocks, then gravel, then eventually mortar when such technology arrived. The road surface represents a geological record of innovation. In some spots, centuries of accumulated dirt buried the original paving entirely. What looks like packed earth road is actually ancient stonework buried a meter down, discovered periodically when erosion or repair work exposes it.

From Borted to Qurol you still see the intentional highly functional design of the Varkaar engineers. The roadbed is built up, creating elevation above surrounding terrain for drainage. Ditches run parallel on both sides, regularly maintained. Culverts channel water under the road at low points. The paving, where it still exists, shows master stonework: fitted blocks creating smooth surface, slight camber for water runoff, buried drainage channels at intervals. Every few kilometers, kilometer markers carved from stone identify distance to

next village in both directions. Some markers are simple and functional. Others are elaborate, featuring decorative elements, inscriptions, even small shrines.

The Varkaar maintain this section most carefully because heavy traffic justifies the expense and because keeping the section of road closest to Bordered in excellent condition demonstrates the superior capabilities of the Cann.

Barból to Byenung is still different, reflecting the southern mood. The road curves rather than cutting straight. It incorporates the landscape rather than dominating it. Here you'll find rest pavilions, prayer towers, carved stones with philosophical inscriptions, trees planted intentionally to provide shade at intervals and water features — fountains, small pools, channels — integrated into the roadside. The engineering is subtle but sophisticated. Drainage works despite the curves. Bridges are beautiful but structurally sound. The road invites walking rather than just enabling it. Travelers often describe the southern arc as peaceful, contemplative, a place where journey matters as much as destination.

The Varkaar still grumble that it adds unnecessary distance.

The relationship between the Varkaar Arms and the Ring Road has changed over centuries. Initially, Varkaar were just security for hire. Caravans paid them. They provided protection. When the caravan reached its destination, the job ended. This created perverse incentives. Varkaar had interest in threats existing to justify their employment, but not in resolving them permanently. Bandit groups sometimes reached accommodation with Varkaar companies: don't hit caravans we're protecting, and we won't hunt you too aggressively.

The Articles of Bordered changed this by establishing regular patrol circuits funded through general fees rather than specific contracts. Varkaar Arms was becoming an organizations that had an interest in eliminating threats rather than just managing them. This is when Varkaar identity crystallized. It is what set in motion all the forces that eventually became the Council, the Cann, the Arms, the Union and the Covenant. They weren't just hired muscle. They were

guardians of the roads, professionals with codes of conduct, an organization with standards and reputation to maintain.

As the Ring Road developed, the Varkaar developed alongside it. They became the primary authority responsible for road security, investigating crimes along the routes, mediating disputes between travelers, enforcing contracts.

Today the Varkaar Arms patrols the Ring Road by agreement with leaders in most of the regions. Their role extends beyond simple security. The Varkaar Arms identify damaged sections, coordinate with local authorities on repairs, sometimes funding improvements from Varkaar Council budgets. Free Innkeepers along the Ring report to Varkaar Arms about conditions, threats, suspicious activities. The road has become an intelligence infrastructure for the Varkaar.

The Varkaar Arms, and especially their elite Báhkar units, on patrol represent authority, order, and the idea that some Saskan institutions transcend local politics. Their presence on the Ring reinforces the still-nascent concept of Saskan unity.

Of course this role is contested. In Dominion territories, Tagabant forces resent Varkaar presence. In rebel regions like Ríkila, Varkaar are viewed as potential enforcers of unwanted authority. In Kahila and Ny lands, in Arq and in parts of Settarune and Baranuq, Varkaar Arms must navigate carefully to avoid being seen as occupiers. The Ring Road binds the Saskan Lands together. But what the Varkaar Arms represent on that road — order or oppression, security or surveillance — depends on who you ask.

Travel on the Ring

For a merchant with a train of trade goods, you depart Bordered in early spring, heading toward Qurol. Your caravan includes six wagons pulled by steady oxen, twenty workers a mix of hum and sint, guards hired from a reputable company, and supplies for sixty days travel. The first week is easy. The road is excellent. You pass Free Inns every two days. Varkaar Arms patrol regularly. You make good time.

Near Qurol, you hire additional guards for the mountain crossing to Eelan. This section is dangerous. There bandits, harsh terrain,

uncertainty about Varkaar Arms protection and the road itself is a mess. You lose time but arrive safely. At Eelan, you sell half your goods and purchase ore to transport back. You debate whether to continue around the Ring or return via the route you came. The full circuit would reach new markets, but the degraded sections near Ríkila and Brokily worry you.

You choose to continue. Through Barból the travel is pleasant, beautiful roads, good food, spiritual atmosphere. Your workers appreciate the rest pavilions. After the long trek to Byenung, you arrange canal transport south into the Ny Lands and Arq for the heavy ore, sending it by barge while the wagons continue by road. This saves time and effort, though you are not entirely sure if the ore will make it safe and sound to the buyers. The southeastern tour along the Ring is lovely. You stop at Morilly to conduct business and rest for several days, and again at Selaron.

Approaching Ríkila, the road deteriorates. Progress slows. One wagon breaks an axle on rough paving. Repairs take three days. You're relieved to pass through without serious incident, though local attitudes toward outsiders are cold. The final stretch back to Pavanoa takes longer than expected due to seasonal rains. You arrive ninety-seven days after departure, having completed the circuit. Your profits are good but not spectacular. You've learned the Ring Road intimately. Its rhythms, its dangers, its possibilities.

You'll do this again next year. The Ring is your livelihood.

The War for Information

The Ring Runners are the official courier service of the Varkaar Arms, subject to the standards and oversight of the Varkaar Union.

The Rabbit Messaging Service (RMS) is an underground courier network, technically illegal in many places, that universally known to provide good service and is widely used.

Stand at the Bordered gates at dawn and watch the couriers depart. First

comes a Ring Runner, mounted on a swift pavan-elk, wearing the distinctive red sash and carrying sealed messages in oiled leather pouches. Official, professional, authorized by the Varkaar Council to move at speed and demand right-of-way on the Ring Road. Ten minutes later, a rabbit-sint slips out a service gate. No uniform, no obvious message containers, moving on foot but moving fast. Within an hour this courier will reach the first RMS relay station, pass messages to the next runner, and return to Bordered before the Ring Runner has covered thirty kilometers.

Both are carrying messages to Selaron. Both will arrive, though by different routes and timelines. Both charge fees for their services. One is legal and official. The other is underground, sometimes quite literally, and technically prohibited almost everywhere. Merchants, councillors of many towns, and even Varkaar Arms commanders use both. Because when information matters, you don't trust a single system. You hedge your bets.

Welcome to the courier wars.

In a world without instantaneous communication, without any way to send messages faster than a living being can physically travel, information moves at the speed of running, riding, or sailing. This creates fundamental realities. Battles are won or lost based on who knows what when. A Tagabant reinforcement unit is moving toward Kahila territory and might be recalled if certain negotiations succeed, but if the message doesn't reach them, they might attack a Kahila stronghold and restart a hot war.

Prices shift based on information about harvests, disasters, or trade disruptions. A merchant who learns about grain shortages in Qurol three days before competitors can buy cheap in Settarune and sell high. Political opportunities emerge and close based on timing. A Varkaar Council vote might hinge on whether a key member receives intelligence about Tagabant movements before or after they cast their ballot. Lives depend on warnings reaching threatened communities before danger arrives. A Varkaar Arms patrol needs to know about bandit movements, disease outbreaks, or hostile forces approaching.

Speed is power. Reliability is wealth. The organizations that move information fastest and most securely control outcomes. The Ring

Runners and the RMS both understand this. Their rivalry isn't personal. For the most part it's existential. Information networks are infrastructure as crucial as the Ring Road itself.

The Ring Runners emerged from the Varkaar' practical need to coordinate across vast distances. Early Varkaar companies communicated by sending armed riders carrying messages. Eventually this formalized into a professional courier service.

The Ring Runners operate more or less as a specialized division within the Varkaar Arms, though with distinct identity and traditions and channels into the Varkaar Union. They're not combat troops, though they train in self-defense. They're specialists in speed, endurance, navigation, and message security.

The Runners would have about 50 stations along major routes, spaced 50-100 kilometers apart. Each station maintains fresh mounts, resting quarters, secure message storage and sorting facilities, and emergency supplies. Messages and fees are categorized as standard (15-20 days), fast (7-12 days), urgent (5-7 days) or secure, which means trusted runners only, with an armed escort.

Ring Runners are recruited from those with exceptional speed, stamina, and navigation skills. Many are from Oknott Province, where harsh conditions breed people comfortable with long-distance wilderness travel. Some are former scouts or hunters. A few are former bandits who reformed and put their knowledge of routes to legitimate use.

Ring Runners have official status. They demand right-of-way on roads, receive priority at Free Inns, and can call on Varkaar Arms for assistance if threatened. Council members, Varkaar Arms commanders, and provincial officials use Ring Runners by default because the service is embedded in official structures. While hum-dominated, Ring Runners include various sints who bring different capabilities. Wolf-sints as guards, cat-sints for night runs, and though rare and politically awkward given RMS competition, even a few rabbit runners.

Ring Runners are easy to identify, track, and intercept. Their routes are known. Their relay stations are fixed targets. Using official

channels means messages pass through systems that powerful parties can monitor, intercept, or delay. Sensitive information may leak. They can't match the RMS's willingness to take shortcuts, use underground routes, or push couriers to dangerous extremes.

The RMS: Underground and Unstoppable

The Rabbit Messaging Service is older than anyone admits, more extensive than official estimates suggest, and completely illegal according to Varkaar Council regulations and proclamations of the New Fatunik Authority that everyone ignores.

The RMS emerged from necessity. Rabbit-sint communities under pressure from huum authorities needed ways to communicate that didn't depend on systems controlled by their oppressors. Early versions were simple. Trusted individuals carrying messages between communities, using knowledge of paths and shortcuts that official routes ignored. As persecution intensified, the networks became more sophisticated. By around the 8th century after the arrival, something recognizable as organized courier service existed, though no one called it that. Rabbits moved information. Others learned to rely on it. Eventually non-rabbits began paying for the service.

The name Rabbit Messaging Service is an external thing. Rabbits themselves call it various things in different dialects: the swift path, the whisper-chain, the long ears (a sardonic self-reference). The bureaucratic acronym RMS came from Varkaar Council documents attempting to track and suppress it. The suppression failed completely but the name stuck.

The RMS operates through decentralized cells with minimal formal hierarchy. This makes it resilient to disruption. Capture or kill one cell, the others continue operating. Unlike Ring Runners with a Bordered guild hall, RMS has no known central authority. Coordination happens through distributed decision-making, traditional practices, and trusted relationships. Local groups (5-15 couriers) operate semi-independently. They maintain their own safe houses, routes, and relationships with customers. Cells coordinate with adjacent cells for message hand-offs but don't share detailed operational information.

Relay posts, also known as burrow stations, are hidden facilities,

often literally underground in warren systems, caves, or concealed buildings. Their location is closely guarded. Only active RMS couriers know where they are. Even regular customers never see them. Messages are picked up and delivered at dead-drops or through intermediaries. RMS couriers are almost exclusively rabbit-sints, though rumors persist of occasional cat-sint and other small, fast species running certain routes. Selection is by invitation only, typically recruiting from villages with RMS history. Trust is built over generations.

A merchant in Bordered, perhaps the same one who uses Ring Runners for a different type of messages to Morilly, has a second message for their Morilly agent one containing sensitive price information they don't want traveling through official channels. They go to a specific bakery in the working district. They order a particular type of bread using specific phrasing. The baker's apprentice, after the merchant leaves, retrieves the sealed message left behind the bread display.

That night, a rabbit courier collects messages from several dead-drops across Bordered. They leave the city through service tunnels known only to a few, emerging miles away from any guarded gate. The rabbit runs. Not on the Ring Road, but on parallel paths: game trails, dried stream beds, shortcuts through scrubland. They cover 60 kilometers before dawn, reaching the first burrow station. There they transfer messages to the next courier, rest in the underground facility, and return to Bordered by evening to pick up another load.

The merchant's message continues south through six relay stages. Unlike Ring Runners' mounted relay, RMS couriers run on foot. The message reaches Morilly in six days, delivered discreetly to a location the recipient specified when establishing their RMS account. The delivery time of 6 days was faster than Ring Runners and the cost was a bit cheaper. The merchant receives no formal confirmation, but the RMS has never lost their messages. Trust substitutes for paperwork.

Ring Runners and RMS compete for the same customers but operate in fundamentally different spheres. The rivalry is intense, sometimes bitter, but also more complicated than simple opposition. Most Ring

Runners acknowledge RMS capability even while resenting their existence. They've seen RMS couriers in action. They know the speeds achieved, the dedication shown, the reliability maintained. Some Ring Runners, especially those from working-class backgrounds or with sint friends, privately admire RMS. Others view them as criminals undercutting legitimate business.

RMS couriers generally view Ring Runners as tools of authority. Not necessarily enemies, but representatives of systems that oppress rabbits. A few respect Ring Runners as fellow professionals caught in different circumstances. The shared identity as couriers creates unexpected common ground. Both understand the particular exhaustion of long-distance running, the elation of successful delivery, the terror of traveling alone and being pursued, the satisfaction of doing skilled work well.

Officially, Ring Runners and RMS never cooperate. In practice, they sometimes do. A Ring Runner encountering bandits on a route might quietly tip off RMS about the danger. An RMS courier learning about Tagabant troop movements might pass intelligence to Varkaar Arms through a Ring Runner intermediary.

Couriers from either service caught in emergencies (injured, stranded by weather, under attack) occasionally receive help from their rivals. These incidents are never officially acknowledged. RMS sometimes uses Ring Runners to move false information, sending messages through official channels designed to mislead enemies while the real information travels via RMS. Ring Runners claim they don't knowingly participate in this, but some suspect it happens.

During the festival, both services cooperate minimally on logistics while preparing for the legendary races. They need each other to make the competition work.

The irony is that everyone uses both. Varkaar Council members send official communications via Ring Runners while using RMS for sensitive messages they don't want logged in official records. Dominion officials publicly condemn RMS while quietly relying on them for intelligence gathering in territories outside of the Dominion provinces. Merchants use Ring Runners for legitimate business and RMS for price-sensitive information, smuggling operations, or

communications with customers in politically complicated regions. Resistance movements obviously use RMS, but also sometimes use Ring Runners to send false information or establish alibis.

The fiction that Ring Runners are the only legitimate courier service is maintained because it's useful to authorities. The reality that RMS moves a substantial portion of Saskan communication is accepted because it's necessary to commerce and coordination.

The Martyrs of Beet

Over the centuries of harsh suppressions in Beet prison camps, rabbits have built and maintained an underground message network connecting prisoners with outside communities. These couriers operate under extreme conditions — moving through work details, hiding messages in food shipments, communicating through coded songs. When discovered, they faced torture and execution but reveal nothing about their networks.

The names of these martyrs are remembered in RMS tradition: Korash, Melina, Two-Toe who lost toes to frostbite but kept running, and others. Songs commemorating them are sung at RMS gatherings. Young couriers learn their stories as examples of ultimate dedication. Such legends serve as recruiting vectors for the Untamed.

The Wildwind Festival: Where Rivalry Becomes Spectacle

Once per year, the professional rivalry transforms into public entertainment.

During the Bordered Wildwind Festival, Bordered hosts a courier competition. Ring Runners and RMS face off in races that draw spectators from across the provinces.

The premier event runs from Bordered to Qurol, approximately 160 kilometers, and back. Competitors can choose their routes, Ring Road direct or any alternative path they prefer. The race typically takes 16-20 hours of continuous running with minimal rest. Spectators

gather at known waypoints to cheer and witness. Ring Runners usually run the direct Ring Road route. RMS couriers take shortcuts, river paths, forest trails, routes only they know.

Over the past 30 years of racing, RMS has won 18 times and Ring Runners have won 12 times.

Wildwind courier races generate enormous betting. The betting is technically illegal but universally tolerated. Some estimate that more money changes hands on Wildwind courier races than any other single event in the Saskan calendar.

Free Inns along the race routes do tremendous business. The Tanabrekt brewery sponsors the event and provides celebratory ale. The entire city basically shuts down for race day.

During Wildwind, Ring Runners and RMS maintain a truce. No arrests, no harassment, no intelligence operations. Couriers from both services drink together at the post-race celebration. The next day, they return to being rivals. But for one day per year, they're just runners celebrating speed and the particular madness of people who make their living carrying messages across vast distances at the fastest pace their bodies can sustain.

Beyond commercial message delivery, both services engage in intelligence gathering and covert operations.

The Varkaar Arms intelligence division operates partly through Ring Runners. Couriers moving through territories observe, listen and report.

RMS serves explicitly political functions beyond message delivery such as coordinating resistance across provinces, connecting resistance cells, smuggling prohibited materials and warning communities about impending crackdowns. The RMS is infrastructure for resistance movements. Their courier network is an underground railroad, an intelligence service, and a coordination mechanism for distributed political action.

Authorities understand this. It's why RMS is illegal. It's also why

attempts to suppress them have failed — destroying RMS would require destroying the rabbit communities themselves. Good luck with that.

As rabbit political organizing intensifies in Bordered, RMS becomes increasingly politicized. Using RMS is seen as statement of support for sint rights. Some conservative customers abandon the service to avoid political association. Simultaneously, RMS gains customers among those sympathetic to rabbit cause. The net effect is probably neutral for RMS volume but changes the customer base's composition.

Ring Runners face pressure to exclude rabbit-sints from courier service. So far leadership has resisted (pragmatically: rabbit runners are exceptionally good), but conservative Varkaar Arms factions push for species restrictions.

The secret both services share is that they both know more than anyone realizes.

Couriers see who sends messages to whom. They observe patterns of communication. They notice when message volume spikes or drops. They hear conversations at inns and relay stations. They witness events unfolding across the Saskan Lands.

Both Ring Runners and RMS maintain strict professional confidentiality. Violating message secrecy is unforgivable. But observing patterns? Noticing trends? Reporting general intelligence about conditions? That's just being observant. The couriers know who's planning what, who's allied with whom, which relationships are solid and which are fracturing. They know because they see the information flowing. This makes them valuable, dangerous, and perpetually caught between conflicting demands for loyalty, profit, and their own survival.

The Ring Road connects the Saskan Lands physically. The couriers connect them informationally. One without the other is incomplete.

Civilization requires communication. Communication requires couriers. Couriers require speed, courage, and dedication that borders on obsession. Both services embody this. They compete fiercely but respect the deeper purpose they serve together.

So they run. Day after day, year after year, generation after generation. They run carrying messages, intelligence, warnings, love letters, business contracts, political manifestos, personal secrets, and everything else people need to send across distances their own feet cannot cross.

They run because the Saskan Lands depends on it. They run because if they stop, the silence would be unbearable.

The rivalry continues. The messages flow. The world turns on information carried by runners who won't quit until their bodies give out or the message reaches its destination.

Whichever comes first.

Dual Governance

The Covenant of Varkaar operates under a dual governance structure that confuses outsiders and occasionally frustrates insiders. At the top sits the Varkaar Council, a body of elected officials who set policy, conduct diplomacy, and oversee economic coordination across all provinces abiding by the Covenant. Running parallel to them is the Cann of Bordered, a collection of military commanders, town administrators, and provincial managers who handle the actual day-to-day operations of government.

The division of power is deliberate. The Varkaar learned long ago that concentrating authority in a single institution invites tyranny, corruption, or both. By splitting legislative and executive functions, requiring cooperation between two power centers, the system creates checks and balances that have kept the Covenant stable for centuries.

It also creates magnificent opportunities for bureaucratic gridlock, political maneuvering, and the occasional spectacular failure when the two bodies cannot agree on a course of action.

Structure and Authority

The Varkaar Council governs the confederation as a whole. Its jurisdiction covers foreign relations and diplomatic agreements as well as standards for trade, coinage, and contracts across provinces. The Council is the leading team for the Varkaar Union, dealing with all aspects of economic coordination. They address the strategic oversight of the Varkaar Arms, which is to say military policy for the Covenant, as well as dispute resolution between the provinces. Formal treaty obligations and defensive agreements are also the purview of the Council.

The Council does not manage individual towns or provinces internally, nor does it command troops in the field. Taxes are collected by provinces and towns, not directly by representatives of the Council. Nor does the Council handle criminal law or social policy and the local level. It is also important to note that the Varkaar Council does not micromanage military or policing operations.

The Council operates through debate, negotiation, and consensus-building. Major decisions require majority support from Council members, who represent different constituencies within the Varkaar system: military, economic, regional, professional.

The Election System

The highest-ranking members of the Varkaar Council are elected every six years, or when there is a conjunction or near-conjunction of all the full moons. This is the only instance of formal voting in the Saskan Lands.

Leading figures in the Council, especially those associated with the Varkaar Union and Varkaar Arms nominate candidates from among those who have distinguished themselves in service. The sitting Council reviews these nominations and selects two or three most

worthy to stand for each open position. This selection process is thorough and occasionally ruthless. Candidates face scrutiny of their service records, financial dealings, family connections, and personal character. The sitting Council has broad discretion to exclude candidates they deem unsuitable. In practice, this means controversial or radical figures rarely make it onto ballots.

While only certain individuals may vote, it is far and away the most widespread example of voting-based democracy in the Saskan Lands. The vote for members of the Council is restricted to registered hum residents of the Covenant Provinces who have publicly sworn loyalty to the Council, are over the age of sixteen turns and are employed in a registered trade or profession. This is far from universal suffrage. Landless laborers, all sints, and those working in trades not recognized by guild authorities may not vote. Turnout varies by province and by how contested the elections are, but typically includes up to 80% of eligible voters.

Winners serve six-year terms. They cannot be removed except by a majority Council vote finding gross misconduct. Turnover is slow, which creates stability but also entrenches power in the hands of established interests.

The Bureaucracy

Below the elected leadership sits an administrative apparatus. Ministries handle foreign relations, trade standards, dispute resolution, record-keeping, voting, and coordination with provincial governments. The bureaucracy operates like a guild. Broodkins enter at low levels, rank up as positions open, and accumulate authority through seniority and competence.

It's a bit of a gerontocracy. The most important posts are held by individuals who have spent decades navigating Council politics. They know where the bodies are buried, which deals were struck in back rooms, which families owe what to whom. This institutional memory provides continuity but also resistance to change.

Elite Council members are well-paid and may benefit from gift-giving that walks the line between gratitude and bribery. But it's nothing like the situation in the Fatunik Dominion, where corruption is systemic

and expected. The Varkaar maintain a cultural commitment to merit and service that constrains, though doesn't entirely eliminate, graft. When corruption is discovered and made public, the Council typically handles it internally by quietly removing the offender, reassigning them to less sensitive posts, or pressuring them to retire. Public trials are rare. The Council prefers to keep scandals from undermining confidence in the institution.

The Cann of Borted

Cann is an old Eibar term meaning assembly of leaders or council of doers. The Cann of Borted manages town administration for Borted itself and the day-to-day operations of the Varkaar Arms, which refers to all aspects of Varkaar military and policing activities, including tactical deployment, logistics, and personnel. The Cann handles Borted's provincial governance, which is pretty much indistinguishable from town governance, in close coordination with village leaders. It handles all practical aspects of military readiness and training as well as infrastructure maintenance such as roads, fortifications, and supply depots. Emergency response and crisis management are also within its purview, although strategic decisions require Council review.

The Cann is not a single body, rather a collection of overlapping roles: military commanders, town administrators, heads of major guilds, and senior members of the Free Hostelrys Cooperative Council. They meet regularly, sometimes daily, to coordinate operations.

Military Command

The highest-ranking military officers in the Varkaar Arms answer to the Cann, not directly to the Varkaar Council. This distinction matters. The Council sets long-term or decisive strategic policy: "We will defend Eelan against Dominion aggression." The Cann decides how to do it. Which units to deploy, what routes they should take, what logistics they require, how they should engage if fighting breaks out. In practice, senior military commanders wear two hats. They

attend Council sessions when strategic decisions are debated. They report to the Cann for operational execution. This dual role creates both coordination and potential conflict.

Town and Provincial Administration

Borded town and province are directly managed by the Cann. They oversee market regulations, building standards, provincial and town tax collection, public works, and law enforcement within the region. The other Varkaar provinces and municipalities maintain their own local governance structures. The Cann coordinates with these local authorities but does not command them. A regional team leader in Liganalupán answers to local mining councils, not to Borded administrators. The Cann can request cooperation, offer resources, negotiate agreements. But it cannot issue orders outside of its purview. This creates a patchwork of authority that works through persuasion and mutual benefit rather than top-down command.

Cooperation and Tension

On most issues, the Council and Cann work smoothly together. The Council sets broad policy, the Cann implements it. Council members attend Cann meetings to provide input. Cann administrators brief the Council on operational realities. Information flows both directions.

For example, the Council might decide it will be important to increase patrols along the northern approaches in response to reports from Oknott of increased Wesshewen raids. The Cann determines how many Varkaar to deploy, from which garrisons, on what schedule, with what supply lines. Council members trust the Cann's operational expertise. Cann commanders trust the Council's strategic judgment.

Problems arise when the two bodies have different priorities or disagree on means.

Let's say the Council wants to fund diplomatic initiatives or trade infrastructure, but the Cann argues for more spending on military readiness or town improvements. Who wins depends on political

alignments and the urgency of competing needs.

The Council focuses on long-term stability and economic relationships, and tends toward caution. The Cann, responsible for immediate security and operations, may favor more aggressive action. After the execution of Henqu and Iohane, some Cann commanders wanted immediate military responses, or at least withdrawal of Báhkar forces from the Ring Road inside Fatunik provinces. The Council chose diplomatic protest.

The Council represents all of the provinces, including Eelan's protected status. The Cann is physically located in Borted and inevitably reflects Borted's interests more strongly. When Borted's priorities conflict with those of peripheral provinces, the Cann becomes an instrument of capital dominance.

When the Council and Cann cannot agree, several mechanisms exist for resolution. Negotiation is usually handled through quiet back-channel discussions between senior Council members and Cann leaders. Most disputes are resolved here. The Council can, by supermajority vote, override a Cann decision and direct the Cann to take specific actions. This is rare and politically expensive. It signals serious dysfunction. In emergency situations requiring immediate response, the Cann can act without Council authorization and seek ratification afterward. This power is used sparingly because abuse would trigger Council intervention. When internal mechanisms fail, either body may appeal to broader constituencies such as guild members, provincial assemblies, military ranks. This almost always makes the situation worse in the short term, but can force a resolution.

Why This System Exists

The dual structure reflects Varkaar philosophy. Power should be distributed, not concentrated. No single person or body should control both policy and implementation. The tension between Council and Cann is a feature, not a bug. The system is designed to prevent tyranny, a key component of the Articles of Borted. A would-be dictator would need to control both institutions simultaneously, which requires building coalitions across multiple and disparate power bases.

The Council represents economic, diplomatic, and regional concerns, while the Cann represents operational, military, and administrative realities. Both perspectives shape decisions and each needs to work together with the other to succeed. Each body can check the other. The Council can refuse to fund Cann initiatives. The Cann can decline to implement Council policies it deems operationally impossible. In a crisis, the Cann can act quickly. For long-term planning, the Council can deliberate carefully. Different situations require different decision-making processes.

The system works when the Council and Cann share fundamental assumptions about the Covenant's interests. It breaks down when they don't. Recent years have exposed growing divergence. The Council, with extensive economic ties to Fatunik territories, generally favors accommodation with the Dominion. Many Cann commanders favor strong reminders when the Tagabant forget the actual balance of military power.

The Council worries about provoking Beshquahoek and disrupting trade. The Cann worries about military credibility. If the Covenant won't defend a protected province, then what good is the protection? Oknott representatives on the Council push for more resources devoted to northern defenses. Bordered-heavy Cann leadership prioritizes maintaining order along the Ring Road and the capital's immediate environs. Younger Council members propose reforms to expand voting rights, reduce the vetting process, and to allow more diverse candidates. Entrenched Cann administrators and senior Council leaders resist changes that might empower unpredictable elements.

The dual governance system has kept the Covenant of Varkaar stable for centuries. Whether it can navigate the current crisis, with external threats mounting and internal consensus fraying, remains uncertain. The Varkaar have built a system that prevents concentration of power. They may now discover whether that same system prevents decisive action when action is desperately need

The Varkaar Union

The Varkaar Union doesn't make laws. It doesn't command armies. It doesn't conduct diplomacy or issue currency. What it does is more fundamental. It decides who works, under what conditions, for what compensation, and according to which standards.

When a carpenter in Sallofòl builds a cabinet, the Union's standards determine acceptable wood quality, joinery techniques, and pricing structures. When a merchant in Liganalupán ships ore to Bored, Union contracts specify weights, measures, delivery schedules, and payment terms. When workers in the Tanabrekt brewery negotiate conditions, Union representatives sit at the table translating demands into enforceable agreements.

The Varkaar Council may govern the confederation and the Cann of Bored may be something like its executive council, but the Varkaar Union runs the economy of the Varkaar provinces and has a huge influence well beyond the region as well. In a society where commerce sustains everything else, that makes the Union the third pillar of Varkaar power, a check on both the Council and the Cann.

What the Union Actually Does

The Union's most fundamental function is establishing and maintaining standards across the Covenant of Varkaar. Without common standards, trade becomes chaos. A bolt of cloth means different things in different regions. A barrel of grain varies by location. Metal purity fluctuates wildly. Contracts become unenforceable because parties can't agree on what was actually promised.

The Union solves this through exhaustive documentation. The Standards Codex, maintained at the Varkaar Union Hall and updated quarterly, specifies:

- **Weights and measures:** Exact definitions for common units, with standardized tools distributed to guild halls for verification

- Material grades: Quality classifications for everything from timber to textiles, with inspection protocols
- Craft specifications: Minimum acceptable standards for guild work (a "master carpenter's table" must meet specific criteria)
- Pricing frameworks: Not fixed prices (the Union isn't stupid), but acceptable ranges preventing predatory undercutting or price-gouging
- Contract templates: Standard forms for common transactions, reducing disputes

Union inspectors travel circuits verifying compliance. Merchants using false weights face fines and potential expulsion from Union-sanctioned markets. Craftspeople producing substandard goods lose their guild certifications. The enforcement isn't perfect. There are plenty of black market traders operating outside Union standards, but it's sufficient to make legitimate commerce function.

The Union coordinates dozens of major guilds, each managing specific trades or professions.

The manufacturing guilds include the metalworkers, carpenters, stonemasons, textile workers, leatherworkers, glassworkers, ceramicists. On the agricultural side there are guilds of grain farmers, orchardists, livestock managers, foresters, and fisherfolk. Service guilds, a major industry, includes the very influential innkeepers, as well as less powerful groups like teamsters, warehouse workers, dock handlers, scribes, brood masters, and teachers. Merchants are also organized into guilds under the umbrella Varkaar Union, each representing trade in major commodities like grain, ore, salt, and textiles. The craft guilds include specialized artisans from Sallofòl and elsewhere: instrument makers, jewelers, fine woodworkers and so on.

Each guild maintains internal governance, sets training requirements for apprentices, manages member disputes, and negotiates collectively with employers or clients. The Varkaar Union provides a framework that allows these independent guilds to cooperate rather than

constantly feuding.

The Free Hostelries Cooperative Council

The most powerful subset of the Union is the Free Hostelries Cooperative Council, an alliance of guilds representing workers who keep Bordered and the provinces fed, housed, and moving. This includes vintners and brewers, including the large and wealthy Tanabrekt brewery, as well as bakers, food processors, innkeepers and hospitality workers, farmers and agricultural workers, miners (but not Eelani miners, who are organized outside of Varkaar structures), teamsters and transport workers and many warehouse and dock workers.

The Free Hostelries council wields enormous practical power. When they threaten work stoppages, food supplies stop, commerce halts, the Varkaar Union goes into something like panic mode and the Varkaar Council usually steps in to bring all parties together to negotiate. When a proposed tax increase on brewing grains would have devastated beer and bread production, it ended within days when the Free Hostelries announced a coordinated stoppage. The Council withdrew the tax proposal.

The Cooperative operates on consensus decision-making, which means they move slowly but carry tremendous legitimacy when they do act. A Free Hostelries resolution represents thousands of workers across multiple provinces speaking with one voice.

Negotiation and Representation

The Varkaar Union doesn't just coordinate between guild masters, business owners, workers and the political institutions of the Covenant and Bordered. Increasingly, it represents workers *against* employers within its own member guilds. This creates fascinating contradictions. The Metalworkers Guild for example, like many other guilds, includes both forge owners and the workers who labor in those forges. When workers demand better conditions, are they negotiating with their guild or through it? The Varkaar answer is both, and it's

complicated.

The Varkaar Union has developed mediation structures attempting to balance these interests. Guild councils include representation from masters, journeymen, and apprentices, though not equally weighted. Dispute resolution boards feature neutral mediators from uninvolved guilds or from the central Union. Labor committees specifically advocate for worker interests separate from employer concerns, a model promoted by the Tanabrekt brewery and now becoming more widespread. Nascent collective bargaining frameworks growing out of the labor committees and beginning to establish standard procedures for negotiating wages, conditions, and benefits.

This system works tolerably well when interests align or disputes are minor. It breaks down when fundamental conflicts arise over centuries-old traditions, as with the current rabbit organizing challenging whether species-segregation either within or between guilds makes any sense. That these types of issues are handled, at least to some extent, via formalized social organizations, is a development that is unique to the Covenant. It is not the same, for example, as the more communal or syndical organizations found in Eelan, Mobalbesq and elsewhere. There are long-established differences in roles, class rank, income levels and so on which are unlikely to be radically transformed any time soon. But the need for mechanisms for addresses friction between the classes is recognized as a problem requiring attention.

Contract Enforcement

Leaving aside labor negotiations, when parties involved in business or financial deals dispute contract terms, the Varkaar Union arbitration mechanisms provide an alternative to Varkaar Council reviews, which are slow, expensive, and politically charged. Union arbitrators who are typically experienced guild members trained in negotiations hear such cases, review evidence, and issue binding decisions.

This makes the Varkaar Union something like a justice system for economic disputes. Merchants prefer it because it's faster and more practical than formal legal proceedings, for which a clear-cut system like that found in the Runes of Bye, which has a formidable legal system, is not in place.. The Varkaar Council is fine with it because it

reduces their workload and keeps commercial disputes out of the political arena.

The Union backs its arbitration with real power. Those flaunting its standards or the decisions of its mediators face being banned from Union-dominated markets, difficulty negotiating future contracts, and being blacklisted from guild membership. For most traders and craftspeople in the Covenant provinces, Varkaar Union sanctions are more immediately damaging than legal judgments of the Varkaar Council, which typically get bumped over to the Cann of Bordered for resolution, which can be another lengthy and politically fraught process.

The Directorate

The Union leadership consists of twenty-one senior members, each representing a major guild constituency. There are currently seven from manufacturing guilds, five from agricultural and resource extraction guilds, four from service and transport guilds, three from the merchant associations and two from craft and artisan guilds.

Directors serve three-year terms. They are elected by representatives from member guilds, with elections happening on rolling basis decided by the sub-guilds. So turnover is uneven and hard to predict, but roughly a third of the Directorate turns over every two years. This creates continuity with a healthy regular infusion of new perspectives. The Directorate reviews challenges and proposals, sets policy, approves updates to the Standards Codex, authorizes arbitration procedures, manages the Union's substantial treasury, and represents the Union in negotiations with the Varkaar Council, the Cann of Bordered and occasionally with officials or representatives from provinces outside of the Covenant.

The Bureaucracy

Below the Board sits a massive administrative apparatus of inspectors, arbitrators, standard-setters, record-keepers, trainers, negotiators, and specialists in every conceivable trade. The Varkaar Union Hall in Bordered houses the central administration, but all the major towns and many larger villages have a Union office, with Bordered, Turno and Mabhakol having multiple halls for different guild

clusters. The bureaucracy operates efficiently when it functions well, but can ossify into self-perpetuating obstruction when it doesn't.

Young people entering the Union bureaucracy face a choice to serve ideals, navigate politics and play favors, or seek to enrich themselves. The best stick to doing the right thing, but the opportunities to misbehave are plenty. The worst become petty bureaucrats protecting turf or worse, corrupt officials extracting bribes.

Power and Influence

The Union's authority derives its ability to coordinate economic activity at scale. Without Union standards, intra-Covenant and extra-provincial trade becomes prohibitively difficult. Merchants need consistent measures. Craftspeople need reliable materials. The Union provides infrastructure that greases the wheels for commerce function well beyond the personal level. This is a major reason why Bordered in particular, and the confederation of provinces around it, are the wealthiest in the Saskan Lands -- even if the distribution of wealth inside the Covenant is far from even.

The Varkaar Union is nascent engine for collective action; it encourages the sense that while individual workers have limited leverage, organized guilds can shut down entire industries. The Free Hostelrys has proved this repeatedly. The Varkaar Council must support negotiations when organizers can halt food production or transport.

The Union is also a clearinghouse for expertise and information. Its army of functionaries know more about actual economic conditions — production volumes, price trends, labor shortages, supply disruptions — than either Council or Cann and this information asymmetry creates power. In a similar way, its proven capability at dispute resolution builds loyalty and dependency and cultural legitimacy. For centuries, the Varkaar Union has represented the idea that skilled work deserves respect and fair compensation, even if it has not always promoted that idea equitably for all workers.

Boundaries

The Union has no military force. If the Council instructed the Cann

to break a Union effort through force, the Union couldn't resist militarily. The Varkaar Arms has a monopoly on weaponry and armor, as well as a high degree of military training. The Varkaar Union can call for strikes, boycotts, and so on, but to encourage an actual fight would both damage their standing in Varkaar society -- it would be a clear violation of the Articles of Bordered -- and it would be futile.

For all of its influence and quasi-monopoly powers, the Varkaar Union relies on functioning markets and industries. Prolonged work stoppages hurt workers as much as guild masters, especially during hard times like bad harvests and natural disasters. The Union must balance its social and political leverage against the survival needs of those it serves.

And of course the Union is wracked by internal divisions. The sub-guilds have competing interests. There are long-standing divisions between huum-dominated versus sint-heavy trades, as well as between elite craftspeople and common laborers, between senior and junior guild members, and between owners or masters on the one hand and apprentices or employees on the other. Building consensus is difficult and sometimes impossible.

The Varkaar Union's authority is strongest in Bordered, weaker in the other Covenant provinces and nearly non-existent in Eelan. In areas outside of Varkaar accords, local arrangements often trump Union standards.

Fatunik markets are by far the largest economic engine outside of the Covenant territories and they operate under different rules. Bordered's economic success depends to a large extent on Dominion trade, and the Union's leverage diminishes when commercial interests pressure the Varkaar Council and the Cann of Bordered to maintain those relationships regardless of Union concerns.

Tensions and Transformations

The organized rabbit protests in Bordered, and the social transformation being encouraged by the Tanabrekt family, challenge many of the Union's structures. All of the current guilds are very much huum-dominated, with sint members relegated to lower ranks or excluded

entirely. The Union has historically justified this through appeals to skill standards and maintaining quality, though significant voices have begun to demand change despite centuries of tradition.

Rabbit-sint organizers, many inspired by Ma Eshuna and Mirae Tanabrekt, some educated by Night Hall scholars, argue this kind of species-based discrimination dressed up in professional language is the relic of dead past whose time has come for change. They point to skilled rabbit craftspeople and to the huge success of Bordered Ale as proof that sint workers can meet any standard. They are demanding an end to species-based restrictions on guild membership, equal voting rights within guild governance, representation for sints on the Directorate. Complex legal briefs inspired by Runik jurisprudence and referencing the Articles of Bordered in detail are being put forward to demand investigation into wage disparities between huum and sint workers doing identical work. And then there are those "outside agitators" who have spent time in provinces with strong communal and syndical traditions, who call for sints and other workers to abandon the Union Guilds altogether and start forming sint-led cooperatives.

The Union leadership is deeply split over how to respond. Progressives support reforms. Conservatives resist. Moderates try to find compromises that are satisfying no one. The Tanabrekt brewery provides a model some progressives advocate: treat workers equally, pay fairly, maintain high standards without species discrimination. If a wealthy ale brewery can do it, why can't other industries affiliated with the Varkaar Union?

Conservatives answer: the Tanabrekt family can afford idealism because they're already absurdly rich. Most businesses operate on thin margins and need to minimize costs. Opening guild membership fully to sints means wage competition will drive down profits and compensation for everyone.

The debate grows increasingly bitter.

And the rabbit organizing movement isn't just demanding reforms within existing unions. They're building parallel structures. Sint workers' cooperatives operate outside Varkaar Union frameworks, establishing their own standards and mutual aid networks. Aligned to

the small but growing independent collectives is the rabbit-sint-organized Mutual Protection Society (MPS), organizing across trades rather than within them, seeking to unite sint workers regardless of trade, guild, or collective. The MPS also runs underground schools to train sint apprentices in crafts officially closed to them, creating skilled workers who operate for now in grey markets.

These alternative structures threaten the monopoly of the Varkaar Union on economic organization. If rabbit-sint workers can organize effectively outside Union frameworks, what does that say about the Union's claimed universality? And what example does it set for other sints, and for huum workers?

Some Union leaders want to crush these alternatives as illegitimate competition. Others want to absorb them, offering incorporation in exchange for accepting Union direction. Still others wonder if the Union needs fundamental restructuring to remain relevant, or if it really even still serves a useful purpose.

Provincial Tensions

The Union, headquartered in Bordered, inevitably reflects Bordered interests disproportionately. Peripheral provinces resent this. Liganalupán miners argue that Union standards favor Bordered manufacturers over raw material producers. Ore prices are controlled while tool prices rise freely. Eelani workers thumb their noses at the Varkaar Union with nearly as much glee as when they are mocking the New Fatunik Authority. Oknott foresters and hunters operate in conditions so different from Bordered manufactories that Union standards seem irrelevant. They follow them grudgingly while developing local arrangements that actually make sense for their work. Sallofòl artisans maintain that Union bureaucracy stifles creative innovation, imposing one-size-fits-all standards on crafts requiring flexibility and experimentation.

The Union maintains legitimacy by providing genuine value, but that value distributes unevenly across provinces, creating resentment that mirrors the political tensions fracturing the confederation itself.

The Wealth Question

The Varkaar Union has substantial financial resources from membership dues, arbitration fees, property holdings, and investments. This treasury funds Union operations, supports funds for members in disputes or during hard times, and provides relief following disasters. But who controls this wealth and for what purposes?

Progressive members argue the Union should invest in worker housing like the Tanabrekt project, and perhaps even education, Dauni Vakasaqua or Dexelite clinics, and other institutions serving the common folk. Conservative members insist the treasury exists to maintain Union infrastructure and support core functions, not to redistribute wealth.

The debate intensifies as the Union grows richer while many struggle. The organization claiming to represent the interests of both the owners and the workers is itself becoming a major economic power with interests potentially diverging, paradoxically in both directions, from those it claims to serve.

Relationship to Council and Cann

The Varkaar Union and the Varkaar Council, and to some extent the Cann of Bored as well, maintain an uneasy partnership. The Council needs the Union's economic expertise and labor management. The Union needs the Council's political authority and the military protection of the Cann and Varkaar Arms. Neither can function optimally without the other, but their interests conflict.

When interests align, the partnership works well. The Council proposes broad policy initiatives; the Union advises on their economic impacts. The Union identifies infrastructure needs; the Council funds improvements. The Union provides intelligence which help to inform strategic and tactical decisions of Council and Cann.

Tensions arise when priorities seriously diverge. Council wants revenue; Union resists taxes on labor and commerce. The Council and the Cann prioritize diplomatic stability; the Union increasingly wants protection for workers threatened by Dominion aggression and rhetoric. Progressive Council members support reforms; conservative Union leadership resists changes threatening guild control. And vice-

versa. The Varkaar Council funds military and administration and likes grand architectural projects to compete with Beshqauhoek. The Varkaar Union wants investment in less sexy but more remunerative economic infrastructure and worker welfare.

These conflicts are managed through negotiation, compromise, and occasionally through confrontation. Neither side can afford permanent rupture, but neither trusts the other completely. The practical reality is that Council and Union each hold veto power over major changes. The Council and Cann control law and military force, but can't govern effectively if the Union calls for stoppages or refuses cooperation. The Union controls economic organization, but can't survive if the Council withdraws legal recognition or uses force to break strikes.

This mutual vulnerability creates stability through stalemate. Neither can dominate the other, so both must negotiate.

The Union's greatest strengths, its institutional stability and established authority, are also its greatest weaknesses. Change comes slowly. Innovation faces resistance. The structures that made the Union successful for centuries may prevent it from adapting to circumstances those structures never anticipated.

What's certain is that economic power matters. The Varkaar Council may make proclamations, but the Varkaar Union moves goods, organizes workers, and coordinates the commerce that sustains the folks of the Covenant of Varkaar. Whatever political changes come, they will have to accommodate the reality that the Union controls mechanisms of economic life that no government can simply commandeer in an effective manner.

The Varkaar Union endures because folks need it to function. The question is whether it can transform to serve broader needs while maintaining the competence and authority that made it essential in the first place.

Hospitality as Power: the Free Innkeepers Guild

Ask any traveler what they know about the Varkaar, and before they mention the Varkaar Arms' legendary patrols or the Varkaar Council's political power, they'll tell you about the inn where they stayed. The one with the clean beds, the fair prices, the hearty stew, and the innkeeper who warned them about bandits on the northern road. The one with the painted shield by the door showing twin oxen.

That's the Free Innkeepers. That's where Varkaar influence lives in practical, daily terms. Not in grand political pronouncements or military displays, but in a warm meal, reliable lodging, and honest dealing when you're far from home.

The Free Innkeepers Guild represents the most visible and arguably most influential face of the Varkaar Union outside the territories of the Varkaar Covenant. While metalworkers and merchants conduct business behind closed doors and guild politics happens in distant Bordered, innkeepers work in the open, serving everyone who travels the roads, seeing everything that moves through their doors.

They're hospitality workers. They're intelligence gatherers. They're peacekeepers. They're the frontline of Varkaar soft power, extending influence through competence and reliability rather than force.

What Makes a Free Inn

Not every inn can display the twin oxen shield. Free Innkeepers must meet specific standards maintained and enforced by guild inspectors. There must be beds with actual mattresses, at minimum straw-filled and with clean linens changed between guests. Rooms are private with functional locks, or there are properly partitioned common sleeping areas. There is adequate ventilation and lighting. Kitchen facilities meets Varkaar Union health standards and there is a functioning waste disposal system, not dumping into the street. And finally, there are stables or other secure animal accommodations.

Furthermore, prices are posted and clean drinking water is available. There is reasonable level of security, including no discrimination based on species or gender. The host will provide accurate information about road conditions and local dangers. All Free

Hostelries Inns provide emergency accommodation for members of Varkaar Arms and official representatives of the Varkaar Union, Varkaar Council or the Cann of Borted, and participate in the Guild's information network.

These are not easy standards. Many independent inns cannot or will not meet them. The ones that do earn the right to display the shield, which brings both benefits and obligations.

The twin oxen shield tells travelers that the establishment meets known standards. Free Innkeepers coordinate with each other; their network is a strong one. Need to send a message to the next town? The innkeeper knows someone. Lost your mount and need to arrange transportation? They can help. Need to find a healer. They will direct you to one. The network functions as mutual aid society and a supply chain. Guild membership provides access to preferred pricing on bulk goods through the Free Hostelries purchasing cooperatives. Beer from the Tanabrekt brewery is available at wholesale rates. There are often discount rates on grain from Baranuq contract, preserved foods from Settarune suppliers as well, and a consistent selection of popular s'lahs from the S'lah Makers of Saskantinon.

The Varkaar Arms patrol routes connecting Free Inns more regularly than they patrol routes without them. Bandits think twice about targeting establishments in and around those with Varkaar Arms connections. The protection isn't absolute but it is very real. When travelers or locals cause problems, Free Innkeepers can call on guild mediation and, if necessary, Varkaar Arms intervention. This matters. An innkeeper without backup is vulnerable to exploitation and having to deal with damages caused by rowdy patrons.

And it is a guild organization. New innkeepers receive mentorship and their staff typically are skilled or are working on an apprenticeship. Struggling establishments get consultation; the guild shares best practices, warns about scams, and helps members weather economic difficulties.

These benefits come with costs, which in almost all cases prove to be well worth it. There are modest but regular dues and compliance to standards is enforced via periodic inspections. Free Innkeepers are required to report to Varkaar Arms about suspicious activity, road

conditions, and local tensions. Failure to do so can result in fines and even losing guild affiliation. Lodging for Varkaar Arms and their mounts must be provided for free or at low rates. In some regions, the twin oxen shield announcing Varkaar affiliation may even attract some hostility from time to time. For most innkeepers, the trade-off for the costs and risks is worth it but in areas where Varkaar authority or politics is resented, the calculation can become complicated.

The Three Tiers

Not all inns bearing the twin oxen shield have identical relationships with the Varkaar Union and the Free Hosteleries Cooperative. In practice, three distinct tiers have emerged:

Tier one are the core network inns. These are fully integrated into the Hosteleries network. Often located at strategic points along the Great Ring Road, in provincial capitals, or at border crossings, they function as important way stations for the Varkaar Arms, who use these inns as key bases for patrols. Rooms are permanently reserved and stables maintain changes of mounts, as well as storage and maintenance of equipment and supplies. The innkeeper of the core inns is often deeply involved in coordinating logistics for the armed patrols.

The core network of Free Inns are the main hubs of Varkaar information flows. Innkeepers maintain detailed logs of travelers, suspicious activities, road conditions, and local tensions and review them regularly with Varkaar Arms. In emergencies, these inns provide secure locations for witnesses, refugees, or special operatives. Core network innkeepers are essentially Varkaar Arms officers who happen to run hospitality businesses. They're paid stipends beyond their normal income and receive training in observation, security, and basic intelligence gathering. Most are former Varkaar Arms patrollers.

An example is the Stone Kettle Inn on the northern Ring Road connecting Khaliro to Rutónik, deep inside the Fatunik Dominion's core province of Rutonijal. It run by Marak Stoneson, a former Báhkar who took over the inn after a leg injury ended his patrol career. The Stone Kettle serves as primary way station for northern patrols, houses emergency medical supplies for injured soldiers, providing healing services for Tagabant as well as Varkaar Arms, and

it maintains a secure room, unknown to local Fatunik officials, where sensitive messages can be exchanged. Marak knows everyone who moves through the region. He tracks seasonal migration patterns of traveling bands, monitors for unusual activity, and maintains relationships with local hunters and river folk who report strange sightings.

The Stone Kettle looks like -- and is -- a simple but well-kept frontier inn. It functions as an intelligence outpost, medical station, an early warning system, and an outpost of Varkaar sensibilities and coordination deep inside Fatunik country, where it exists without conflicts.

The second tier consists of affiliated inns. These establishments benefit from guild membership and display the twin oxen shield, but maintain distance from direct Varkaar Arms operations. They are common in areas where local populations are politically mixed or volatile and Varkaar presence and influence is minimal, for example in the Ny Lands, where tribal authorities tolerate but are neither enthusiastic about Varkaar patrols, nor do they have long-standing interdependencies with the Varkaar business or military concerns. Affiliated inns are also more common in areas like the more remote parts of Baranuq and Settarune where competition from non-affiliated inns is strong.

The affiliated inns provide standard Free Hosteleries level of hospitality and participate in information sharing, but don't serve as way stations or safe houses and limit how publicly they associate with the Varkaar Arms. This allows them to maintain some plausible deniability about being effectively an arm of the Cann. They sometimes even go so far as to remove or obscure the twin oxen shield when political winds are shifting in an unfavorable direction.

The guild tolerates this ambiguity because maintaining presence in contested areas serves Varkaar interests even when full integration isn't possible. For example, The Traveler's Rest is an affiliated Free Hosteleries Inn located in the southernmost part of the Runes of Bye, right on the Bay of Bar, not far from the frontiers with the Ny Lands to the east and Baranuq to the west. Managed by Hesina Qurolsdaughter, who purchased the inn using proceeds from her

brood family's Free Hosteleries Inn in Qurol. The Traveler's Rest displays the twin oxen shield on a small bit of ironwork near its cornerstone. Hesina maintains guild standards and participates in the hospitality network, but Varkaar Arms patrols this far south and this far from the Ring are rare. She carefully manages her relationship with Varkaar Arms contacts, teams from the Nylander Free Trade Association and mariners from Kurosol, who appreciate being able to dock at a friendly port during their voyages around the Bay. When Varkaar Arms stay at the Traveler's Rest, they pay full rates and receive no special treatment... publicly. When FTA guards dine there, Hesina serves them with equal professionalism. She provides both with carefully curated information that serves her interests, which is to say, maintaining good relations with powerful parties while avoiding becoming anyone's spy.

This balancing act requires skill and constant vigilance. Hesina succeeds because she's genuinely committed to good hospitality rather than political agendas. Both sides tolerate her divided loyalties because the Traveler's Rest is genuinely excellent, and everyone benefits from a well-kept neutral space where business can be conducted.

The third tier are name-only affiliations, which are in fact not affiliations at all. Some establishments try to claim Free Innkeepers affiliation without actually maintaining standards or participating in the network. They paint a shield and trade on the reputation without earning it. The guild polices this through inspections and policing actions, but in very remote areas enforcement is difficult and in some cases, the inns are well-managed, thus enhancing and not tarnishing the Varkaar reputation. The more successful third tier "Free Inns" have never seen an inspector. Of course, this creates problems when travelers expect Free Inn standards and receive subpar service. Problems for the travelers and, if they are well connected, problems for the innkeepers as well. The guild's reputation suffers from sub-par establishments they can't effectively monitor. A fraudulent Free Hosteleries Inn in Barból would get reported and shut down quickly. In distant Arq, enforcement is nearly impossible.

The Competition

Not every good inn is a Free Hosteleries Inn. Plenty of excellent establishments operate independently, and some explicitly position themselves as alternatives to Varkaar-affiliated hospitality. In fact, most inns across the Saskan Lands have no guild affiliation at all. They're traditional businesses, local traditions, or entrepreneurial ventures operating on their own terms. Quality varies wildly. Some independents resent the Free Innkeepers' advantages and they complain that the Bordered-based guild operates an unfair monopoly suppressing honest competition. The Free Innkeepers, if they bother to respond at all, point to the Cooperative's principles and the standards published by the Varkaar Union, noting that anyone meeting the standards can apply to join. The relationship between affiliated and independent inns ranges from friendly competition to bitter rivalry depending on local personalities and economic pressures.

Romperi Houses

The most significant newly organized competition comes from Kahila romperi, a parallel hospitality tradition emerging from Kahila forest communities. Romperi houses offer communal rather than private accommodations, unless specifically requested. Vegetarian-only food in strict adherence to ancient Kahila ascetic principles. Integration with nature, with structures designed to minimize environmental impact, often blending so well into the surroundings that they can be difficult to see at first. Negotiation-based pricing. Guests offer pay what they feel is fair; innkeepers accept or reject. The unwritten and unannounced benefit is that they operate as safe houses for those fleeing authority, whether that authority comes from Fatunik or Varkaar or Runik law.

The most famous romperi house, the Inn of the Full Moons, operates in Ríkila, the rebellious town in the Fatunik province of Pavanarune. The establishment openly competes with a Free Inn in the same town. Travelers choose between them based on sympathies and needs. Merchants conducting business with the Varkaar stay at the Free Inn. Kahila activists, sint refugees, those suspicious of Varkaar authority prefer the romperi house and merchants looking for new business

opportunities stay at the Full Moons. Both survive because they serve different constituencies. The romperi houses infuriate Dominion authorities, who correctly see them as hotbeds of Kahila sympathies that harbor criminals, as well as some Free Innkeepers who view them as undermining standards. Others grudgingly respect them as legitimate alternative approaches to hospitality. A few Varkaar innkeepers have visited romperi houses and admit that they learned a number of useful techniques.

Fatunik Hostelries

The Fatunik Dominion maintains its own hospitality network, the Blessed Accommodations, which tend to be tied to Fatunik temples and related scribal societies, rather than to trade guilds in the Varkaar style. These establishments enforce strict Fatunik religious observance for guests and segregate accommodations by species (huum separate from sints), gender and rank. Prayers are required before meals and different rates are charged based on perceived level piety of guests. They will report suspicious and heretical activity to Tagabant authorities. Blessed Accommodations serve Fatunik loyalists very well. Pretty much everyone else avoids them whenever possible.

Inside Dominion territories, travelers -- and not only Fatunik travelers -- face a choice. Stay at a Free Inn that maintains Varkaar guild standards, where accommodations will be top-notch, but risk political scrutiny by the Watchers and the Tagabant, or stay at the Blessed Accommodations offering Fatunik-approved lodging along with surveillance and discrimination, or take a risk on an independent establishment, with wildly varying quality.

The presence of Free Inns within the provinces of the Fatunik Dominion represents a locus of soft resistance to Fatunik control. They are spaces where species segregation isn't enforced, where religious conformity isn't required, where alternative values find a mild expression through hospitality practices. Increasingly, they are also popular for being a place where you are guaranteed to be able to order a round of Bordered Ale. Conversely, Blessed Accommodations

located outside of the Dominion serve as a soft reminder that Fatuniks believe all of the Saskan Lands are their domain and also act as a welcome refuge for Fatunik travellers concerned about their safety when traveling through unclean lands.

The Varkaar Intelligence Network

The Free Innkeepers of the Hosteleries Cooperative of the Varkaar Union serve as the eyes and ears of the Varkaar Arms across the Saskan Lands. This isn't sinister secret spy work. It occurs quite openly and focuses mainly on practical information gathering that emerges naturally from hospitality operations. Innkeepers notice who travels where, what people say and they notice behavioral anomalies like travelers asking unusual questions or paying with suspicious currency. They are the early warning system for noticing rising prices, crop failures, brewing disputes, and conflict areas, not to mention things like bandit activity, reports of wild animals, damaged bridges, dangerous weather, and seasonal hazards.

Innkeepers report this information not because they're spies but because they care about travelers' safety and their own business interests. If bandits are hitting the extensions from the southern Ring Road towards Wildwind, innkeepers want the Varkaar Arms to know so patrols can respond and trade can continue.

Information flows up through the network. Local innkeepers note significant developments and their Reports are passed to regional Free Hosteleries representatives. Consolidated intelligence reaches Varkaar Arms commanders, usually stationed at or near one of the core Inns. Messages regarding urgent or dire matters go directly to Bored via fast riders. The system is informal, decentralized, and surprisingly effective. Most Free Innkeepers aren't trained intelligence analysts, but they develop intuition for what matters through experience and mentorship.

The Tanabrekt Innovation

The Tanabrekt family, riding their success with Bordered Ale, is currently developing a new concept: establishments focused primarily on serving ale, with food and limited lodging as secondary offerings. They're calling them pubs — short for public houses, with the implication being that they are simply public gathering places — and are planning to open the first experimental locations in Bordered's commercial districts.

The concept involves spacious common rooms designed exclusively for socializing and provisioning of multiple ale and s'lah varieties on tap. Not just Bordered Ale, though of course it is prominently featured. Simple, high-quality, quickly-prepared "fast" food is available like cold taq and cheese and chewable roots. There are no private or shared sleeping rooms. Various types of entertainment like musicians, storytellers, and other performers are invited and prices are affordable enough for the services to be enjoyed on a regular basis, not just on special occasions.

The Tanabrekt vision is to create spaces where working people can gather, relax, build community, and enjoy quality ale and perhaps even nod off briefly, without needing to afford full inn accommodations. The Free Innkeepers are watching this development with mixed feelings. Some see it as competition threatening their food and drink revenue. Others view it as complementary; pubs can handle socializing and drinking while inns can focus on lodging and full meals.

A few innkeepers are even exploring partnerships. They are thinking to operate a Tanabrekt pub on ground floor, then maintain inn rooms above. The romperi have already fully embraced this model, though they have little interest in allowing the Tanabrekt family any controlling interest. The Tanabrekt family is open to franchising their concept, potentially creating a parallel network to Free Inns. The first Tanabrekt pub opens in Bordered next spring. If successful, they plan expansion across provinces and potentially beyond Covenant territories. The cultural implications are significant. Pubs as spaces for working-class socializing, bearing progressive political symbolism, serving ale to mixed species gatherings without segregation or hierarchy. It pushes the soft impact of the Free Inns to the next level.

Whether Dominion authorities will tolerate Tanabrekt pubs remains to be seen.

Innkeepers see what others miss. They connect people and information. They provide the daily human infrastructure making complex societies function.

The twin oxen shield represents more than quality lodging. It represents a vision of how commerce, community, and care for travelers can coexist. Whether that vision survives the coming conflicts depends partly on political developments beyond innkeepers' control. But it also depends on whether, when travelers arrive exhausted and hungry at the end of a long day, they find clean beds, hot food, honest dealing, and someone who treats them with dignity regardless of their species, wealth, or political sympathies.

That's the hospitality that matters. That's what the Free Innkeepers, at their best, provide. And that's why the twin oxen shield still means something to people who've been far from home and found shelter under it.

The Varkaar of Justice

The Varkaar Arms is not exactly an army, though it can fight like one. It's not just a police force, though it investigates crimes and apprehends criminals. It's definitely not a merchant guild, though it has a duty to protect commerce and enforces contracts. The Varkaar Arms a professional military and investigative organization that has guarded the arteries of trade across the Saskan Lands for four thousand years. This covers everything from guarding frontier posts in the cold north to patrolling paths through the Ny Lands and Arq, far to the south, that could only be called a trade road by someone with a vivid imagination.

The name itself is a bit opaque. All residents of the Covenant provinces refer to themselves, in certain contexts, as Varkaar. They are the people who uphold the Articles of Bordered as agreed to by the Covenant of the 'Varkaar of Justice' - VarKaar in Old Eibar. When they patrol on mounts, take up armor and carry weapons, they become the Varkaar Arms, the armed riders of the Saskan Lands.

Their reputation exceeds their numbers. Five thousand Varkaar cannot physically patrol every kilometer of the Ring Road simultaneously, cannot investigate every theft, cannot respond to every crisis. What they can do is project credibility. The mere possibility that a mounted and armed Varkaar might appear on the Ring Road near your town or village, might witness a crime, might track a fleeing bandit, might arrive with reinforcements, changes behavior. Merchants travel with confidence. Bandits think twice. Local disputes get settled before they escalate into feuds that might draw Varkaar attention.

This works until it doesn't. And increasingly, it doesn't.

What They Actually Do

Their primary mission remains what it has always been: keeping the Great Ring Road open and safe for trade. Varkaar Arms patrol the Ring in pairs or small groups, following circuits that take them through major towns, past common ambush points, along mountain passes and river crossings where trouble tends to concentrate.

They stop at way stations, check in with local authorities, gather intelligence on bandit activity or dangerous animals, assess road conditions, mediate disputes between travelers. The work is mostly routine, weeks of riding punctuated by occasional moments of crisis.

Varkaar Arms have very good equipment, excellent training, a well-functioning support network and a broad authority to act. If they witness a crime, they feel free to arrest suspects on the spot, no matter how far they are from the frontiers of the Covenant of Varkaar. If they encounter travelers in distress, they provide assistance, regardless of species, religion or language. If they find evidence of organized criminal activity, they investigate and pursue. They're expected to use judgment, to know when to be lenient and when to be firm, to understand that the Articles of Bordered serve different purposes in

different contexts.

This discretion is both their greatest strength and their greatest vulnerability. Varkaar soldiers earn trust through fair dealing and sound judgment. But when Varkaar Arms abuse their authority, take bribes, or settle personal scores, which does happen, it is treated as a stain on the entire organization -- something its critics are quick to use against them.

Investigation and Intelligence

Beyond patrol work on the Ring and subsidiary roads, and on the frontier, the Varkaar Arms maintain a sophisticated investigative apparatus. When crimes cross provincial boundaries, when organized gangs operate along the Ring Road, when mysteries require more than muscle to solve, the Varkaar Arms dig deep.

Elite investigators track patterns in theft reports, interrogate captured bandits, share information widely, and maintain networks of informants across towns and villages. They work with local authorities when possible, around them when necessary. The best investigators become legendary for their ability to unravel complex schemes, expose corruption, and bring sophisticated criminals to justice.

This work requires different skills than road patrol: patience, subtlety, the ability to piece together evidence from fragments. Some of the Varkaar Arms excel at it. Others find it tedious and prefer the straightforward clarity of protecting a caravan from attack.

Emergency Response

When disaster strikes, whether it is floods, fires, bandit attacks on settlements, outbreak of disease, the Varkaar Arms mobilize. They coordinate rescue efforts, provide security for healers, facilitate communication between affected communities and provincial authorities. In remote areas, Varkaar Arms may be the first organized help to arrive and the only real authority figure for hundreds of kilometers.

This role has expanded in recent years as threats multiply. Strange

sightings in the northeastern and northwestern territories. Raids from increasingly organized bandit confederations. Dominion training exercises that bring ever-expanding Tagabant forces uncomfortably close to Varkaar territories, or making un-asked-for forays into the Outer Lands or Settan territories. The Varkaar Arms find themselves responding not just to natural disasters and common crime, but to situations that blur into military operations.

The line between emergency response and the potential for the war that everybody dreads, pitting Varkaar Arms against the Tagabant, grows thinner every turn.

Structure and Ranks

The Varkaar Arms operates through a combination of formal hierarchy and professional respect.

The majority of members are field Varkaar Arms. Junior and senior patrols who spend most of their time on the road. They answer to circuit commanders who oversee specific regions. Specialist investigators focus on complex cases, intelligence gathering, and coordination with local authorities. They have authority to commandeer resources and request support from field Varkaar.

Mid-level officers are circuit commanders who oversee patrol routes, assign personnel, handle logistics with a sub-region. They report to regional commanders. Senior officers responsible for larger sections of the Ring Road or regions connecting to it. They coordinate with both the Varkaar Council for strategic policy and the Cann of Bordered for operational execution.

The Báhkar are neither a formal rank, nor a special unit, but a recognition within the Varkaar Arms of fighters with singular capabilities. The Báhkar are veteran of the Varkaar Arms with exceptional skill and proven character who have been invited to join by existing Báhkar. Upon receiving the badge, they take additional oaths, maintain higher standards, and often handle the most sensitive or dangerous assignments. Henqu and Iohane were Báhkar, which made their execution particularly shocking.

The highest military leadership of the Varkaar Arms are part of the

Cann of Bordered. They set operational priorities, manage budgets, approve awarding of the Báhkár designation, and handle discipline for serious misconduct.

Promotion depends on a mix of seniority, competence, and political connections. Most members of the Varkaar Arms advance slowly through the ranks and only a few rise quickly through exceptional service or fortunate patronage. Some plateau and serve out careers at the same level, respected for their experience but lacking the political skills or ambition for leadership.

Training and Recruitment

The Varkaar Arms draws recruits from across the Covenant territories, though Oknott provides the lion's share. Young people join for various reasons. Steady pay, escape from difficult home situations, family or village tradition, genuine idealism about serving a greater cause, or simple lack of better options.

Basic training is intensive and lasts six months. It covers ridership and care of mounts, weapons proficiency with sword, pike, bow, poles, knives and hand. All are required to study basic legal and investigative procedures, to learn how to provide first aid and emergency medicine and to handle skills in navigation and wilderness survival. There is also training in cultural sensitivity and conflict de-escalation. The training is demanding but not brutal. Instructors weed out those who lack discipline or show troubling aggression. The goal is to build very high levels of competence, not to break spirits. The Varkaar Arms needs professionals, not brutes. The comparison with Tagabant training is often noted, and it is the main reason why it is widely assumed that the Varkaar Arms, despite fewer numbers, would win any match against the Dominion's armed forces.

After basic training, new members of the Varkaar Arms serve two-year apprenticeships paired with experienced officers. This is where real education happens: learning to read situations, to judge when force is necessary and when restraint is wiser, to navigate the complex social dynamics of the myriad of diverse towns and villages along the Ring Road and beyond.

Some of the Varkaar Arms serve their whole careers at this level and

are content. Others pursue specialized training in investigation, emergency response, diplomatic liaison, or advanced combat techniques. The Varkaar Arms supports professional development because highly skilled personnel are the organization's core asset.

Equipment and Appearance

The romanticized image of a Ring rider of the Varkaar Arms, immaculately uniformed, armor gleaming, mount perfectly groomed, carrying an impressive array of perfectly-kept weapons, projecting effortless authority very much has a basis in reality. During ceremonial events, official functions, and formal inspections, the Varkaar Arms do look magnificent. Their uniforms feature intricate embroidery reflecting provincial traditions. Their equipment shows the craftsmanship of Sallofòl workshops and Liganalupán forges.

Then they ride out for a three-week patrol through autumn rains, and reality asserts itself.

Uniforms get mud-spattered and torn. Armor develops scratches and dents. Mounts go lame and need to be rested. The Varkaar sleep in rough way stations or under stars, eat dried rations or whatever local hospitality provides, and deal with the accumulated grime of weeks on the road. After weeks away from a bath, they look tired, weather-beaten, and far less impressive than the songs suggest.

The Varkaar Arms maintain their gear and their personal appearance as well as circumstances allow. They keep their weapons sharp and their mounts healthy. But at Fatune's rest, they project authority through competence rather than appearance. The worst let standards slip, become sloppy and careless, trading on their position rather than earning respect through service.

Many of the Saskan public mostly sees the Varkaar Arms at their best: entering towns for scheduled stops, responding to emergencies, presiding over public ceremonies. They don't see the exhausted riders who limp into rural way stations after eighteen-hour patrols, or the investigators who spend weeks sifting through contradictory accounts trying to piece together truth in a village located well past the back of beyond.

Current Challenges

The Varkaar Arms faces pressures from multiple directions.

Fewer young people are choosing service in the Varkaar Arms. Pay remains steady but not competitive with opportunities in expanding trades. The work is dangerous and often lonely. Provincial militias offer similar prestige with less travel and better local connections. The Varkaar Arms depends on Council appropriations that must be negotiated, debated, and distributed across competing priorities. Uniforms wear out faster than they're replaced. Mounts need constant care and periodic replacement. Weapons require maintenance. Medical supplies run short. The gap between what's needed and what's funded widens each year.

The Varkaar Arms are asked to handle more and more complex problems with the same resources. Investigate Fatunik spy networks without causing diplomatic rows. Monitor sint political activity without triggering protests. Respond to increasing bandit sophistication. Patrol northern territories where strange threats emerge and bizarre murders still occur in remote, lonely areas. Each expansion of responsibility dilutes focus and stretches personnel thinner.

The execution of Henqu and Iohane exposed fractures within the Varkaar Arms itself. Some insisted on immediate retaliation against the New Fatunik Authority. Others supported the Council's cautious approach. The disagreements became personal, bitter, divisive. Varkaar Arms who once trusted each other now are questioning each other's loyalties.

Some folks from Eelan Province joined the Varkaar Arms expecting full integration and support. Instead they watch their province drift toward High Weir while Bordered dithers. While some Eelani Varkaar have resigned and returned home to the mountains, others remain but grow increasingly disaffected. The unity the Varkaar Arms depends on is fraying amongst its Eelani contingent.

The Varkaar Arms includes sint members, though far fewer proportionally than the general population. Rabbit-sints, wolf-sints, and various others have proved their competence and loyalty. After

decades of service, these heroes now face questions about where their true allegiances lie. The rabbit protests in Bordered create impossible situations. The Varkaar Arms are asked to arrest protesters who might be their cousins, their neighbors, their childhood friends.

Legendary Varkaar

The Varkaar Arms has always celebrated its heroes. Songs, stories, and annual commemorations keep their deeds alive. Some legends are centuries old, polished smooth by retelling. Others are more recent, their details still sharp and disputed. Here is a sampling...

Saela the Swift rode down a gang of highway robbers single-handedly, rescuing a merchant caravan and recovering stolen goods worth a small fortune. Her speed and agility became the standard against which later Varkaar Arms measure themselves.

Aron the Wise solved the mystery of coordinated thefts across multiple provinces, discovering that what appeared to be random banditry was actually an organized smuggling network. His investigative methods are still taught to new recruits.

Vara the Fearless tracked a professional assassin across three provinces, surviving multiple ambushes before finally apprehending her target and preventing the murder of a prominent Mobali guild master.

Orlan the Just mediated a bitter land dispute between two Ny Land villages that had feuded for generations, finding a solution both sides could accept and establishing peace that lasted decades.

Elys the Protector single-handedly defended a small Settarune village from a Tidejack gang, holding them off until reinforcements arrived, suffering severe wounds but saving countless lives.

These stories serve multiple purposes. They inspire new recruits, they communicate professional values, they remind the public what Varkaar aspire to be. The fact that most Varkaar Arms never achieve anything comparable to these legendary feats doesn't diminish the stories' power.

The Next Generation

But legends are for the past. The Varkaar Arms needs living examples, folks grappling with current realities, making hard choices, showing what it means to serve when service demands more than glory. One response to Tonedor Rumpet's attack on the Báhkar has been to send bards out all along the roads to tell the stories of Varkaar Arms who are less well-known than the famous singing Báhkar.

These are some of their stories.

Mirikel Tornassdaughter is a senior investigator from the Bordered Central Command of the Varkaar Arms. She has seen 47 turns. From Oknott Province, daughter of loggers, recruited at 19, Mirikel spent fifteen years in field patrol before transitioning to investigative work. She is known for obsessive attention to detail and ability to extract information from reluctant witnesses through patience rather than intimidation. She currently is leading the investigation into how foreign agents infiltrated Eelan Town before the murders that sparked the Time of Fire. This is a cold case everyone thought closed until recent evidence suggested the official story was incomplete. (The implication is that her findings could embarrass powerful figures in the Dominion.) Mirikel is methodical, quiet, politically neutral. When she finds evidence that points to conclusions, those conclusions are reported. She is Báhkar, sworn to truth above convenience.

Jalen Quickblade is a circuit commander on the western Ring Road between Eelan and the Borda Woods. He has run 34 turns. From a Liganalupán mining family, joined the Varkaar Arms at 20 turns after a mine collapse killed his father and two brothers. He has had rapid promotion due to high skill levels. Jalen handles a busy section of the Ring Road connecting Eelan settlements, parts of the Borda Woods and the southern approaches Qurol. His circuit deals with smuggling, unsanctioned border crossings, and tensions between Eelani miners and both Bordered and Borda Woods merchants. Jalen joined the Varkaar believing in the ideals. He does his job competently, maintains good relationships with local authorities, and is building a network of allies.

Kasira vel Marn is a diplomatic liaison for the Varkaar Arms. With 51 turns, from Sallofòl Province, Kasira joined the Varkaar Arms at 25,

abandoning a career in the artisanal guilds. Her specialty is neither combat nor investigation but negotiation, cultural translation, and diplomatic finesse. She rose through administrative positions to become a primary liaison between the Varkaar Arms and the Varkaar Council and a frequent delegate in meetings with officials from non-Covenant provinces. When the Council debates policy, Kasira explains operational realities. When field commanders want more resources, Kasira navigates the political process to secure funding. She's the translator between two different languages of power, a bridge across the Council-Cann divide. Kasira is Báhkar and knew Henqu and Iohane personally. She considered resigning her post, but instead is building coalitions for a more forward military policy and expansion of the Varkaar Arms, recognizing that the Dominion responds only to strength.

Tovan Swiftfoot is a field worker of the Varkaar Arms. At age 23, from a rabbit-sint family in Bordered's warehouse district, he grew up sorting grain and loading carts. Applied to the Varkaar Arms at 15, passed all tests with exceptional scores, completed training despite facing a level of scrutiny that huum recruits seldom experience. he's a respected field Varkaar known for his speed, his ability to defuse tense situations, and his skill at gathering intelligence from communities that may not trust huum authorities. He's exactly the kind of professional the Varkaar Arms values: competent, dedicated, ethical. Tovan believes in the Varkaar Arms, believes in the mission of protecting travelers and maintaining order. He also believes his folks deserve better treatment than they receive in many places. He doesn't see these beliefs as contradictory.

The Báhkar

The Báhkar represents the Varkaar Arms at its best, veterans of proven skill and unquestionable character who have taken additional oaths and hold themselves to higher standards. Membership is by invitation only, extended by existing Báhkar to Varkaar Arms who have demonstrated exceptional service over years or decades.

The oaths are private, but the general commitments are known: truth above convenience, duty above personal interest, service above advancement, the good of the whole above provincial loyalties.

Báhkár are expected to lead by example, to mentor younger Varkaar Arms, to take the difficult assignments, to speak uncomfortable truths to power. In practice, the Báhkár function as an elite guard, a moral authority within the Varkaar Arms, and occasionally as internal investigators when serious misconduct needs to be addressed. They're respected but also somewhat apart. Their additional oaths create distance from ordinary Varkaar Arms who haven't taken the same vows.

The execution of Henqu and Iohane was more than the murder of two Ring Varkaar. It was a calculated insult to the Báhkár and, by extension, to the Varkaar Arms' highest ideals. That the Council responded with diplomatic protest rather than decisive action is seen by many Báhkár as problematic. Tensions are running high. Some Báhkár argue for patience, trust in the Council's judgment, faith that justice will come through proper channels. Others advocate for independent action, perhaps a Báhkár mission to rescue imprisoned folks from Fatunik jails, or retaliation against Dominion targets, or at minimum a public break with Council leadership that has failed them.

So far, discipline holds. But the bonds of brotherhood can fray when brothers and sisters die unavenged.

What Holds It Together

Despite the pressures and fractures, the Varkaar Arms remains highly functional. Patrols continue. Investigations proceed. New recruits train and deploy. The institution endures. What keeps it together is not ideology or perfect leadership or unlimited resources. It's the relationships between individual Varkaar Arms who trust each other, who have ridden together through danger, who know they can count on their partners when everything goes wrong.

A veteran showing a rookie how to read terrain for ambush points. An investigator sharing intelligence with a field commander who needs it. A northern patrol sending warning south about strange sightings. A Báhkár quietly mentoring a junior officer who shows promise. These connections, built one interaction at a time over years of service, create resilience that formal structure cannot provide. The Varkaar Arms will fracture when these relationships break down, when

members stop trusting each other, when provincial loyalties trump professional bonds, when personal interests override collective mission.

That breaking point hasn't arrived yet. But it grows a bit closer every day.

The Varkaar Arms built their extraordinary reputation over four thousand years. They maintained the Ring Road through the Age of Scarcity, through the Kahila conflicts, through the Time of Fire. They are professionals, skilled and dedicated to a mission larger than themselves.

The question is whether professionalism and dedication are sufficient when the world around them demands choices their system was never designed to make.

The roads remain open. For now.

On the Rabbit Question

Many rabbit-sints of Bored carry small drawings of Ma Eshuna in their pockets. Folded paper, cheap ink, worn soft from handling. They show these drawings to each other in quiet moments in the back rooms of warehouses where they sort grain, in their narrow sleeping quarters above workshops, in the pre-dawn stillness before the markets open. A reminder. A promise. A saint who suffered and returned, who taught that even the smallest can resist the largest if they do so together, with discipline, with patience, with unbreakable resolve.

The Varkaar Council is discovering that patient, disciplined resistance is far harder to suppress than spectacular violence.

In the Fatunik Dominion, where rabbit-sints face systematic persecution, open harassment, forced labor, and public execution for heresy, the Untamed responds with fire and blood. Wolf-led rabbit

commandos strike Tagabant patrols. Infiltrators sabotage granaries. A recent attack on the Shining Temple itself during the Gleaming ceremonies created chaos and terror. The message is clear: if you burn us, we burn you back.

In the Covenant of Varkaar, where rabbit-sints technically have legal personhood and the right to petition for redress of grievances, the resistance takes a different form entirely. They sit. They gather. They present demands. They cite law.

The Varkaar are learning which approach to fear more.

Someone has picked up where Ma Eshuna left off and is now teaching the rabbits legal theory. Not just basic rights and obligations, but sophisticated argumentation drawn from Byenung precedent, from dense texts like the Axiomata of Sustained Return, and even from obscure codicils in centuries-old trade agreements. Rabbit petitions arrive at the Council offices written in precise legal language, referencing specific passages from foundational texts, building arguments that would earn approval in any Night Hall seminar.

"Pursuant to the Third Filigree, that which ceases to give ceases to grow, and that which circles does not bind. We submit that labor extracted through coercion rather than contract violates the principles of sustained return upon which Varkaar commerce depends. We therefore request renegotiation of terms..."

The suspicion, widely shared but never proven, is that Night Hall scholars are providing more than just education. Indeed, some rabbit leaders have been seen in Byenung town. Prominent Byenung legal theorists have published articles questioning the philosophical foundations of huum supremacy. The Varkaar Council has quietly asked the Night Hall to discourage this sort of unhelpful speculation. The Night Hall has quietly, politely and diplomatically declined.

What They Want

The demands vary by location and circumstances, but certain themes repeat. Recognition of labor rights, meaning fair wages paid in coin,

not scrip. Contracts negotiated between equals. Right to refuse dangerous work. Access to guild membership for skilled trades. Legal standing, such as full rights to petition courts, testify in disputes, bring suit against huum employers. And end to discriminatory bail and sentencing practices.

They are also petitioning for the right to practice rabbit spiritual and religious traditions openly, observe feast days, and maintain shrines to Ma Eshuna and Malavorra without harassment or mockery. The discussion over political representation is sensitive and cautious, suggesting non-voting advisory positions on local councils and perhaps, eventually, the vote itself. Demands for educational access are more forceful, requesting admission to guild schools, libraries, and access to apprenticeships on the same terms as huum youth.

These demands are presented not as revolutionary manifestos, rather as applications of the Articles of Bordered. They quote the Council's own rhetoric and snippets from the Articles about merit, fair dealing, and the dignity of honest work. They point to contradictions between Varkaar ideals and Varkaar practice. They argue from within the system, using the system's own logic.

It's devastating.

Their protests are disciplined, organized, and strategically sophisticated.

There have been sit-ins at public buildings, with dozens of rabbits occupying the front steps of the Council Hall, the Varkaar Union offices, and major guild halls. They sit in silence, holding signs with short, clear demands. They remain non-violent even when harassed. When arrested, they go limp, forcing guards to carry them away one by one while crowds of merchants and foreign visitors watch.

Work stoppages are riskier, but have been tried. A coordinated refusal to work until specific demands are met can bring some economic operations to a halt. There are not permanent strikes that could be broken by bringing in replacement workers, but unannounced rotating actions that disrupt operations without destroying livelihoods. One week the rabbit dockworkers. Next week the warehouse sorters. Then

the tannery workers. The timing seems random but never is.

Rabbit-sint communities in Bordered coordinate to refuse to purchase from specific merchants or guild houses known for more exploitative practices. The boycotts are announced publicly with clear conditions for ending them. Some merchants cave immediately. Others suffer months of lost revenue before negotiating.

Despite accusations of interference by Runik scholars in Bordered affairs, hundreds of lengthy legal petitions, filed properly through official channels, requesting hearings on grievances, have been filed in recent months. The Council bureaucracy is drowning in paperwork trying to keep up with them. Each petition must be reviewed, logged, scheduled for potential hearing.

Public prayers and mourning pull at everybody's heart strings. After every Dominion atrocity, every lynching or beating death of a rabbit-sint somewhere in the Dominion, every execution, every Tagabant raid against rabbit gatherings, rabbits gather in Bordered's plazas to pray for the dead and injured. They name the victims. They sing mourning songs. They do this without permits but without violence, daring the Varkaar to stop them from grieving.

Once Ma Eshuna herself appeared at such an event and the gathering attracted thousands, the majority of whom were not rabbit-sints.

The Impossible Bind

The Varkaar Council faces a dilemma with few good options.

They could try violent suppression. Send in Varkaar Arms to break up protests, arrest organizers, ban assemblies. This is exactly what the Fatunik Dominion does. It would prove that every accusation the Untamed makes about hum rule is true. It would alienate foreign merchants who trade in Bordered specifically because it's not the Dominion, with especially damaging repercussions across the southern provinces. And it would likely trigger actual violence from rabbit militants who have so far held back in Covenant territories.

Negotiation is increasingly being considered across a whole range of

demands. Meet with rabbit leaders, discuss demands, make incremental concessions. This would legitimize sint political claims, setting a precedent that organized pressure works. The feat is that every other sint group and the more exploited huum workers, for that matter, such as the miners of Liganalupán, would learn the lesson. The entire social structure that privileges huum above all others, and Bordered most of all, would begin to crack.

Another option, which seems to be the current strategy is to ignore them and hope they will go away. Refuse to engage, wait for the protests to fizzle out. But they don't fizzle. They grow. Trade interruptions increase. Dominion representatives watch and judge Bordered's ability to maintain order, opening in-roads for the Fatunik huum chauvinists to promote their views more widely. The longer the protests continue, the more the Council appears weak, indecisive, unable to govern, and the more Fatunik propaganda about the natural order of things has an influence across its western borders.

Different Council members favor different approaches. The Cann, responsible for maintaining order and less concerned with philosophical niceties, leans toward suppression. Younger Council members, and those with ties to the Night Hall or to Terpinol, argue for negotiation. The old guard tries to find a middle path that satisfies no one.

Meanwhile, the protests continue.

What the Dominion Sees

Fatunik observers watch Bordered's rabbit troubles with great interest. Some see confirmation of their beliefs. Bive sints any freedom at all and they become ungovernable. Better to keep them firmly under heel from the start.

Others see opportunity. If the Covenant of Varkaar tears itself apart over the rabbit question, the Dominion can expand its influence without military action. Already, conservative and traditional elements in Bordered are starting to argue that the Council should coordinate with the Dominion on joint sint policy. The logic is

seductive: only through huum solidarity can order be maintained.

This is exactly what the New Authority wants, for the Varkaar to abandon their distinct political culture, to forget that the Articles of Bordered make no distinction between huum and sint, and ultimately to accept the Dominion's ideological leadership.

What the Rabbits See

The rabbit-sint organizers understand the game they're playing. They know they're not going to win full equality this turn, nor next turn, nor probably in their relatively short lifetimes. But they're shifting the conversation. They're building organization. They're doing exactly what Ma Eshuna taught them to do, training the next generation in tactics of resistance and making allies.

They're forcing the Varkaar to choose, publicly and repeatedly, between their stated ideals and their material interests. Every time a Council member says "We value fair dealing" while refusing to negotiate with rabbit workers, the contradiction is exposed. Every time a Varkaar guard arrests a non-violent protester, the distance between Bordered and Beshqauhoek shrinks. Every time the Covenant fails to uphold on the Articles of Bordered, more rabbits decide the Untamed's approach makes more sense.

The drawings of Ma Eshuna pass from pocket to pocket. The quiet meetings continue. The demands are refined, presented again, refined again. The patient work of resistance continues, one small disciplined step at a time. And every once in a while, the dedicated street cleaners of Bordered have to wash away a scrawled portrait of Malavorra or of a howling wolf, symbols of the Untamed, from walls.

The Varkaar built a system founded on principles of negotiation, dignity, fair contracts, and rule of law. The rabbits are calling their bluff.

The Jewel of the North

Stand on the eastern heights at dawn and watch Bordered wake. Smoke rises first from the bakers' district, then from forges and smithies as fires are stoked for the day's work. The river catches first light, turning silver where it splits around the old town islands. Bells ring from guild halls calling workers to their trades. The great cranes at the warehouse district begin their slow rotation, lifting cargo from barges that arrived overnight.

By mid-morning, the streets throng with commerce. Merchants from Sallofòl display fine craftsmanship in the artisans quarter. Liganalupán ore brokers negotiate prices in counting houses. Eelani metal traders argue terms in three languages. Fatunik visitors gawk at the prosperity while trying not to look impressed. Rabbit-sints haul carts through narrow service alleys. The occasional wolf-sint in a finely woven Varkaar Arms uniform is seen patrolling the main avenues.

This is Bordered. Wealthy, confident, cosmopolitan, and increasingly aware that its wealth depends on arrangements that cannot hold forever.

Bordered sprawls across both banks of a northern tributary into the Pavan, with the oldest settlements on three river islands connected by ancient stone bridges. The city has grown in concentric rings outward from this core, each expansion reflecting the prosperity of its era.

The Old Town

The three islands remain the ceremonial and political heart. Here stands the splendid Varkaar Council Hall, the original Varkaar Arms garrison - now administrative offices for the Council, the ancient Temple of Fatune, which is diplomatically maintained in pristine condition, and some of the oldest guild halls.

Narrow streets wind between buildings that have been rebuilt, modified, and expanded over two millennia. No comprehensive plan

governs the layout. Organic growth created a maze of passages, courtyards, hidden gardens, and sudden open plazas. Locals navigate by landmark and habit. Visitors get lost.

The Council Hall dominates the islands and the town. Its towers and minarets can be seen from everywhere in the city, a constant reminder of the Covenant. The Temple of Fatune, on the other hand, is deliberately modest, never having been expanded in all the centuries. It large enough to serve the Fatunik community of Bordered, but not so large as to suggest Fatunik authority supersedes the Articles.

The New Districts

Across the main bridge sprawls the commercial heart of modern Bordered. This is where money moves, goods change hands, and fortunes are made or lost.

In the banking district solid stone buildings with heavy doors and small windows define the ambience. Here the counting houses manage credit, exchange currency, issue the Bordali vellum bonds and wooden chits that facilitate trade across the Saskan Lands. Byenung-trained clerks keep meticulous records. Armed guards watch entrances. Fortunes flow through ledgers and locked strongboxes. The banking district operates on trust and reputation. A merchant's word, backed by the right surety, is worth more than gold. Default on obligations and you'll never borrow again. The bankers of Bordered remember everything.

In the extensive warehouse quarter, trade becomes tangible. Massive stone and timber structures store grain and produce from Baranuq and Settarune, metals and minerals from Liganalupán and Eelan, textiles from Baranuk and Kahilabequa, tools from Sallofòl workshops, furs from Oknott and salted meat from the Fatunik north. The warehouses employ hundreds of checkers, haulers, guards, clerks, and teamsters. Many are sint workers living in cramped housing above or behind the warehouses.

Great wooden cranes lift cargo from river barges. Wagons queue at loading docks. Arguments over weights and measures erupt

constantly and are just forcefully put to rest by reference to the Council standards. The Free Hostelrys Cooperative Council maintains offices here, mediating disputes and enforcing standards. The warehouse district smells of river water, preserved wood, and whatever goods currently dominate. Sawdust when Oknott timber is shipping downriver, metallic tang when ore arrives, yeast when the grain warehouses open their doors.

The artisans quarter is more aesthetically appealing than the purely commercial districts. Here craftspeople display wares in shops with large windows. Jewellers, fine furniture makers, musical instrument workshops, bookbinders, specialized tool-makers. Along with the quotidian goods on display, this is where wealthy buyers browse and commission custom work. The artisan quarter cultivates an atmosphere of refined taste. Street musicians perform. Small gardens soften the stone. Cafés serve expensive imported teas. The message is clear. Boreded has more than raw economic power; it has culture.

The guild halls, dozens of them, are scattered throughout the north bank, each guild maintaining its own hall reflecting the trade's character. The Carpenter's Hall is all exposed timber and intricate joinery. The Metalworker's Guild features elaborate ironwork gates. The Varkaar Union Hall, by far the largest of all, combines fortress architecture with merchant prosperity.

Manufacturing and Working Districts

The south bank is louder, grimmer, and where the actual work happens.

The Forges is where Boreded manufactures the weapons, tools, and metal goods that feed its economy. Dozens of smithies, large foundries, specialist workshops producing everything from farming implements to ceremonial swords. The air tastes of coal smoke and hot metal. The rhythm of hammers creates a constant percussion. Workers here are skilled and proud of it. The metalworkers' guilds wield significant political influence. When they threaten work stoppages, the Council negotiates quickly.

The tanneries and leather works are relegated to the far south bank

where the smell won't bother wealthier districts. Here hides from across the provinces become saddles, boots, armor, belts, pouches, and endless other leather goods. The work is hard, the smell powerful, the pay modest.

The textile quarter is devoted to spinning, weaving, dyeing, and finishing. Boreded doesn't produce raw textiles. Those come from Settarune, Baranuk and Kahilabeq, but it processes them into finished goods. Conditions vary from decent guild workshops to cramped sweatshops where overseers extract maximum production from desperate labor.

Working-class housing for both humm and sint is packed tight behind the industrial districts. Narrow multi-story buildings where multiple teams share common spaces with minimal amenities. The Cann of Boreded maintains public wells and basic sanitation, but conditions deteriorate the farther from the city center one goes. Conditions for rabbit-sint families live are worse still. This is where Liganalupán miners' children grow up after moving to Boreded seeking better opportunities, where recent arrivals crowd into whatever housing they can afford.

The New Garrison and Varkaar Arms Facilities

The western expansion houses military and security functions.

The Varkaar Arms New Garrison is new in that it is only several hundreds of turns old. It houses training grounds, stables for hundreds of mounts, armories, barracks, and administrative buildings. It is a city within the city, capable of housing and supporting two thousand Varkaar Arms, plus support staff, at any given time.

The garrison maintains parade grounds for ceremonies and public displays of military capability. Visitors are welcome on scheduled tour days. The message is unmistakable. The Covenant of Varkaar has the strength and the will to defend its interests.

The foreign quarter, not accidentally, is adjacent to the garrison. Here reside long-term visitors from other regions. There are Dominion

merchants and officials who maintaining Bordered offices, Empafarasi traders and visitors, Byenung and Mobalbesq scholars and merchants. Even a few Kahila representatives operate in Bordered under diplomatic protections. The foreign quarter features buildings in various architectural styles representing their inhabitants, along with temples and shrines to different deities, restaurants serving regional cuisines, and a cosmopolitan atmosphere that is quite distinct from the rest of Bordered. It's watched closely by Varkaar intelligence units, but is left largely autonomous.

The Heights

Above and away from commercial bustle, the wealthy of Bordered -- among the wealthiest folks in all the Lands -- have built their residences. Large villas with gardens, walls separating them from common streets, private courtyards, and architectural flourishes advertising prosperity. Council members live here. Senior Varkaar Union officials. The most successful merchants. Guild masters. Banking consortium leaders. The oldest families, the ones that have accumulated wealth over generations and now maintain it through careful management and advantageous marriages, keep large compounds on the Heights.

The area is quiet, clean, and peaceful. Crime is nonexistent. Private guards are everywhere. The contrast with the crowded working districts below is stark and deliberate. Bordered, while it exists to protect the Lands and its system of governance protects checks and balances, makes no pretense of being an egalitarian community.

Architecture of Power

The Varkaar Council Hall is one of the most opulent buildings in all the Saskan Lands. Ancient and extravagant, it features architectural innovations seen nowhere else so elaborately combined. The Council Hall occupies all of the largest island in the old town core. Approaching it requires crossing one of three bridges, each guarded by statues of a legendary hero of the Varkaar. The grounds are

extensive. There are gardens, courtyards, training yards, stables, and administrative wings. The main building rises in stages. First, a broad base of pale stone featuring elaborate carvings depicting scenes from the Migration. Then, progressively taller levels adding complexity with balconies, colonnades, and ornamental stonework. Finally, the mass of towers and minarets that define Boreded's skyline.

The towers are impossibly tall and thin architectural achievements that shouldn't work but do through some combination of ancient engineering and possibly subtle enhancements. Some are purely decorative. Others house bells, observation posts, archive rooms accessible only by ladder-like stairs and possibly other functions. The bell towers ring on the hour, marking time for the entire city. Their tones are tuned to create harmonies, so the hourly chiming becomes a brief musical performance.

Gates and Walls

Multiple layers of walls surround the complex. The outer walls are defensive, ten meters high, and thick enough to walk along the top. The inner walls are more ornamental, featuring decorative stonework and integrated gardens. The main gate features elaborate metalwork, possibly created in Sallofòl, possibly much older, (the details have been lost) that moves on hidden mechanisms. During ceremonies, the gates open in coordinated motion, sections rotating and sliding to create a dramatic entrance. How this works is closely guarded knowledge maintained by specialist engineers.

Lesser gates provide access for daily business. Service entrances handle deliveries and staff movement. Emergency exits exist too but are unmarked and known only to security personnel.

Interior of The Great Hall

The Great Hall of the Varkaar Council is the public emblem of Varkaar governance. It can accommodate several hundred people for major assemblies, celebrations, diplomatic receptions. The ceiling

soars overhead, supported by columns that feature spiral carvings representing the Covenant provinces. Natural light enters through high windows featuring colored glass. It is not religious imagery like in the Fatunik temples, but geometric patterns and stylized representations of Varkaar history. When Fatune's light streams through, the floor becomes a mosaic of moving color.

The acoustics are remarkable. A speaker at the central dais can be heard clearly throughout the hall without shouting. Whispers carry strangely, so private conversations near the walls are impossible. Some suspect this is deliberate architectural surveillance, though no one admits as much.

The Council Chambers

The chambers are where actual governance happens. It is a circular room with tiered seating, allowing Council members to face each other. The ceiling features a painted map of the Covenant provinces, updated over the years as boundaries and settlements changed. The chamber features something rare in the Saskan Lands: an internal irrigation and climate control system. Water flows through channels in the walls, moderating temperature. In summer, the chamber stays surprisingly cool. In winter, warm water keeps it comfortable. The mechanism is another closely held secret.

Hidden passages and chambers exist throughout the complex, many unknown even to current Council members. Some are simple storage or service corridors. Others reveal themselves dramatically during specific rituals or ceremonies. Walls slide open, floors rise to reveal hidden chambers, mechanical surprises that remind visitors that the Varkaar possess capabilities beyond their obvious wealth.

The Archives and Libraries

Below ground, protected from fire and flood, stretch rooms containing records dating back to the before the arrival. Treaties, contracts, court decisions, census records, military dispatches, personal journals donated by notable Varkaar. The archival holdings rival those of the Night Hall, though they are organized very differently. Access is

tightly controlled. Scholars may request specific documents through applications reviewed by archival committees. Some sections remain sealed, accessible only to highest-ranking Council members. What they contain and why they're protected is subject of speculation.

Private Wings and Living Quarters

The Council complex includes residences for senior officials who need to be available at all hours. These apartments are comfortable but not ostentatious. The Council like to maintain at least the appearance that service rather than luxury motivates leadership. Private meeting rooms, secure chambers for sensitive discussions, meditation spaces, even small temples to various deities for members' personal worship. The building acknowledges that governance requires both public spectacle and private deliberation.

The Banking System

Borded's wealth derives from being the middleman, the facilitator, the place where goods and capital converge before dispersing again. The city produces goods and services, but mostly what it produces is coordination, credit, standards, and security. Borded's banking houses manage the credit that makes large-scale trade possible. A merchant in Mobalbesq can purchase Liganalupán ore using Borded-issued credit, which the ore broker then converts to local currency or uses to purchase other goods, all backed by banking houses that guarantee the transactions.

This system concentrates wealth in Borded. Every transaction extracts fees. Every loan charges interest. Every currency exchange benefits the exchanger. The provinces produce value; Borded captures it. The bankers argue they provide essential services like risk mitigation, contract enforcement, dispute resolution, stable currency standards and insurance contracts. This is true. It's also true that they profit enormously from these services while the actual miners, farmers, and craftspeople see more minimal returns.

The Free Hostelries Cooperative Council

The FHCC is an umbrella organization coordinating multiple guilds and industries: vintners, brewers, bakers, innkeepers, farmers, miners, teamsters, warehouse workers. The Cooperative Council sets standards, negotiates wages, manages disputes between member guilds, and maintains collective bargaining power against employers. The Cooperative wields significant political influence. When they threaten work stoppages, food supplies and commercial operations stop. The Varkaar Council negotiates with them carefully, aware that popular unrest often begins when basic goods become unavailable or unaffordable.

The Cooperative is dominated by huum leadership, though sint workers make up large portions of actual membership. This creates internal tensions as rabbit organizing suggests alternative models of worker solidarity that cross species lines rather than reinforcing them.

Manufacturing and Trade

Borded manufactures weapons and armor for the Varkaar Arms and for export to other provinces. The province also supplied farming implements like plows, harrows, scythes, and others tools for maintaining agricultural productivity as well as hand tools for every trade from carpentry to mining. And the region produces processed goods, taking in raw materials and creating finished products for wider distribution. Each manufacturing sector employs hundreds. Each creates supply chains reaching into other provinces. Liganalupán ore becomes Borded swords. Oknott timber becomes Borded furniture. Southern grains and roots become Borded bread and beer. The value added at each step concentrates in Borded. The city grows wealthy while peripheral provinces provide raw materials for a modest but steady return.

The Contradiction

Varkaar ethics based on the Articles of Borded emphasize fair dealing, honest weights and measures, contracts honored, and protection of the vulnerable. The reality is that Borded's prosperity

depends on systematic extraction of value from provinces with less negotiating power. This contradiction doesn't go unnoticed. Liganalupán miners grumble about selling cheap and buying expensive. Eelani traders compare Borted's promises with Empafarasi offers. Even Oknott loggers understand they're getting the worse end of every deal.

The Varkaar Council maintains the system through combination of genuine services like security, contract enforcement, dispute resolution, control of credit, and the threat that alternatives might be worse. Borted's exploitation is predictable and it operates under clear rules. The Fatunik Dominion offers no rules at all, just submission to arbitrary authority. But increasingly, the periphery questions whether these are the only options.

Social Life and Culture

Borted town is cultured, cosmopolitan, and refined. Theater, music, poetry, and visual arts thrive. Borted's wealthy patrons commission work, support artists, attend performances, and display cultural sophistication as proof of their city's superiority. The most celebrated performers are bards like Birakay of the Qurol Riverwaq, whose golden voice packs venues. But Borted also produces its own talent: playwrights who satirize provincial prejudices gently enough not to offend too much, musicians who blend traditions from different regions, poets who write in multiple languages.

The artisan quarter hosts galleries displaying art works from across the Saskan Lands. Wealthy collectors compete to own pieces by notable craftspeople. The Sallofòl jewellers maintain permanent exhibitions. Even controversial works from Kahila artists find audiences, though carefully framed as anthropological interest rather than political statement.

Borted celebrates extensively. Each guild has feast days. Each season brings ceremonies. The Varkaar Arms hold military parades. The Fatunik community observes religious holidays. There are small communities of river-soul celebrants and Returners as well, with their

own unique contributions.

But the largest celebration of all is the Wildwind Feast, marking the autumn harvest and the turning of seasons. It is Bored's adaptation of the famous Nylander feast. For three days, normal work stops. Markets transform into festivals. Competitions test skills from archery to poetry composition. The legendary race between Ring Runners and RMS couriers happens during Wildwind, drawing spectators from across the provinces.

During Wildwind, social hierarchies relax slightly. Wealthy and working classes mix in the streets. Sint and huum celebrate together. For three days, Bored remembers that underneath all the stratification, they're supposed to be a community.

Then Wildwind ends and everyone returns to their normal positions.

Education

Bored maintains schools for children of wealthy and guild families. The curriculum includes literacy, mathematics, history (carefully curated), and practical skills relevant to anticipated careers. More advanced education happens through guild apprenticeships or, for the ambitious and connected, sponsored study journeys to the Night Hall institutions in Byenung to the Terpinol Academy. For working-class families, education is minimal and mostly practical. Children learn trades from brood parents and community elders, pick up literacy if their work requires it, and otherwise receive little formal instruction. This perpetuates social stratification across generations.

The Varkaar Council maintains extensive libraries and archives, but access is restricted. Knowledge is power, and power is not shared freely.

Current Tensions

Bored's prosperity and confidence mask growing pressures.

The organized rabbit protests concentrate in Borted because that's where both economic power and political leverage exist. The warehouse district workers, the textile quarter employees, the service workers maintaining wealthy households, all have substantial portions of rabbit-sints who have watched their Dominion relatives burned alive while Borted's elite conduct business as usual with the executioners.

The protests disrupt commerce, create uncomfortable optics for foreign visitors, and force the question: does Borted believe its own rhetoric about fair dealing and rule of law, or only when it's convenient?

The wealthy districts remain largely insulated. But the working districts simmer. When rabbit organizers call work stoppages, warehouses sit idle, goods don't move, profits don't accumulate. The Council can order a crackdown, but violence against non-violent protesters would shatter Borted's self-image as fundamentally different from Dominion brutality. And increasingly the rabbit-sints are finding allies among other workers, both in the town and in other parts of the allied provinces.

Other provinces see Borted's wealth and resent it. Liganalupán produces the metal. Oknott provides the timber and much of the personnel for the Varkaar Arms. Sallofòl creates the craftsmanship. Eelan mines the ore. What does Borted contribute except taking a cut of everyone else's labor? The answer — financial services, security, coordination, standards — is technically correct but emotionally unsatisfying. The provinces want more equitable distribution. Borted wants to maintain the arrangements that made it wealthy.

This tension plays out in Council negotiations, trade disputes, and growing calls for restructuring how the Covenant actually distributes resources and power.

Borted's extensive economic ties to the Fatunik Dominion also creates vulnerabilities. Fatunik merchants operate in Borted. Lots of them. Borted banks hold large amounts of debt from Dominion provinces. Borted manufacturers sell weapons and tools to Fatunik customers, which among other things creates a strange situation in which the Varkaar arm those who seem likely to one day be their

most dangerous rivals: the Fatunik Tagabant.

If Tonedor Rumpet decided to close Dominion markets or default on debts, Bored would suffer significant economic shock. This reality shapes Varkaar foreign policy in ways the Council won't publicly acknowledge. They cannot afford to antagonize the Dominion too severely without risking the prosperity that legitimizes their governance. The execution of Henqu and Iohane revealed this vulnerability starkly. Bored's response was constrained not primarily because of military calculations but by economic exposure. That constraint breeds contempt from provinces less enmeshed in Dominion commerce, particularly in Eelan, which sees alternatives.

The Eelan Drift

As Eelan cultivates closer relationships with High Weir, Bored watches a critical province slip away. The Eelani bring strategic resources — metals, minerals, mining expertise — and an easily defensible territory that could block routes into the northern provinces of the Covenant of Varkaar. More importantly, they represent a test. If Eelan can successfully distance itself from Bored while maintaining security and prosperity through Empafarasi partnership, what's to stop other provinces from pursuing similar arrangements? The confederation is held together through perceived mutual benefit. If the benefits flow overwhelmingly to Bored while costs and risks distribute to the periphery, why remain unified?

Bored has no good answers. It can offer better terms, but that sets a precedent for other provinces to demand similar concessions. It can threaten withdrawal of protection, but that's effectively admitting the protection is conditional and transactional rather than based on a genuine commitment to the Articles. The Council debates endlessly. Meanwhile, Eelani delegations visit High Weir more frequently and Bored delegations visit Eelan less often.

Internal Divisions

Borded itself fractures along multiple fault lines. Wealthy merchants favor accommodation with the Dominion. Younger Council members push for reform and confrontation. Military families want stronger responses to provocations. Working-class districts align increasingly with sint political organizing. The consensus that maintained Varkaar governance for centuries is eroding. Each issue, whether relations with the Fatunik Dominion and the New Fatunik Authority, or rabbit-sint protests, resource distribution, Eelan's status, each creates new coalitions and deepens existing divisions.

The town that projects confidence and prosperity struggles internally with fundamental questions about what it stands for and whether it can maintain the systems that created its wealth without becoming the exploitative power structure it claims to oppose.

To its supporters, Borded represents the best of what the Saskan Lands can achieve: prosperity through cooperation, security through strength, culture through patronage, governance through merit rather than heredity or divine right. It's the alternative to Fatunik religious authoritarianism, to the mysterious isolation of the Empafarasi, the haughtiness of the Runik folk and the unpredictability of the southerners.

To its critics, Borded represents exploitation wrapped in appealing language. It is a system that extracts value from periphery to center, that maintains hum supremacy while claiming enlightenment, that talks about fair dealing while rigging every transaction in its favor.

Both views contain truth.

Borded is wealthy because it provides genuine services while also exploiting structural advantages. It's cultured because prosperity enables patronage while that same culture serves class interests. It's governed through elections that are embedded into entrenched networks that determine who gets nominated in the first place.

The city and province of Borded stands at a crossroads. It can adapt, expanding political participation, distributing wealth more equitably, taking principled stands even at economic cost, or it can double down on arrangements that have served its elite well even as those

arrangements generate increasing resistance.

What Boreded decides in the coming years will shape not just its own future but the fate of the entire Covenant of Varkaar. For now, the smoke rises each morning from forges and bakeries. The bells ring marking hours. The merchants haggle in multiple languages. The bankers count coins and issue credit. The warehouse workers haul cargo while organizers pass folded papers.

Boreded continues. How much longer it continues in its current form remains to be seen.

And then there's the business of the beer.

Ale, Fire, and Redemption

Every resident of Boreded knows the tower. Six stories of solid stone and timber, rising above the working districts south of the river, topped with the copper brewing vessels that catch Fatune's light and shine like beacons. The tower isn't the tallest structure in Boreded/ The Council Hall's minarets claim that distinction. But it's the most beloved.

At the tower's peak flies a flag bearing a simple image: a black rabbit in profile, ears alert, looking toward the horizon. Below it, in letters large enough to read from across the river: Boreded Ale - The Drink of the Ring.

This is the Tanabrekt brewery. And the story of how a family of exploitative Fatunik conservatives became the most progressive major employer in the Covenant of Varkaar, and impossibly wealthy in the process, is one Boreded tells with pride.

The Old Days

Before the fire, before the transformation, there was Old Tanabrekt. That was Joram Tanabrekt, master brewer, strict Fatunik adherent even though his family had been in Boreded for generations, ruthless businessman, and according to contemporary accounts, an absolutely

miserable human being.

Joram inherited the brewery from his father, who inherited it from his father, stretching back through centuries to the early days of Borted's settlement. The Tanabrekt family had always brewed ale. It was one of the few alcoholic beverages available in a land without grapes, where hops and grain were precious commodities, where the very act of consuming alcohol carried social and religious significance.

In a culture where vegetarian and carnivore were political as much as culinary positions, where nutrition came primarily from grains and vegetables for many, the brewing process consumed resources that could feed people. Ale wasn't just a luxury; it was a statement. Only the wealthy could afford to convert valuable grain into drink.

The Tanabrekt brewery produced small batches of exceptional quality. Their ale graced the tables of Varkaar Council members, wealthy merchants, guild masters, and visiting dignitaries. It was served at formal ceremonies, diplomatic receptions, and celebrations among Borted's elite. Everyone else drank water, weak tea, the occasional fermented fruit juice on special occasions when fruit was plentiful, and of course the ubiquitous s'lah.

Joram liked it this way. He ran the brewery with iron discipline, employing a small staff of rabbit-sints who worked long hours for minimal pay. They slept in cramped quarters attached to the brewery. They ate what he provided. They worked when he commanded and rested when he permitted. The rabbit workers couldn't quit. Where would they go? Other employers offered similar conditions or worse. At least the brewery was stable work, and Joram didn't beat them. He was exploitative, but within the accepted norms of the time. That was almost a recommendation.

Most of the community hated him anyway. His ostentatious displays of Fatunik piety rattled the more ecumenical Borted sensibilities. His public pronouncements about the proper hierarchy of hum above sint and his donations to Fatunik causes while his workers lived in squalor; it exacerbated tensions and it generated resentments that Joram seemed to enjoy.

"Let them hate," he reportedly said, "as long as they respect the

quality of my ale."

Then Joram died. Suddenly, unexpectedly, at 67 turns, collapsing in his office after a particularly heated argument with his daughter about workers' conditions.

He left three children: Mirae, Dannok, and Kels. The inheritance was messy. The will was unclear. The family fought. And Bordered watched with fascination as the Tanabrekt dynasty tore itself apart.

Three Visions

Mirae Tanabrekt, the eldest at 41, had spent years managing the brewery's operations alongside her father while fighting with him constantly about everything. She knew the business intimately: the recipes, the suppliers, the equipment, the workers. She also knew the workers' names, their families, their grievances.

Mirae had quietly converted to a syncretic faith combining elements of the old Fatunik beliefs from the Ingar schools with deep respect for Ma Eshuna, the founder of Terpinol Academy. This horrified her father, who saw it as betrayal of both faith and family. She wanted to transform the brewery into a workers' cooperative, expand production modestly, and use profits to improve conditions rather than enrich owners. She argued this was both ethically right and good business. Happy workers produce better ale, she said, and having a reputation for fair treatment would attract the best brewers and laborers.

Her brothers thought she was naive.

Dannok Tanabrekt, the middle child at 38, was the visionary and the gambler. He'd traveled extensively through the provinces, studied production and manufacturing techniques in Eelan and Mobalbesq, and had observed the Pollination Guilds' organizational methods during travels throughout the southern territories. He saw the brewery's potential to become a major commercial enterprise.

His vision was expand production tenfold, distribute Bordered Ale across all the provinces, make it affordable enough that working folks of all ranks could enjoy it during festivals and celebrations, and build the Tanabrekt name into a brand recognized everywhere in

Saskantion. This would require massive investment in equipment, facilities, and distribution networks. It would require taking risks. And it would required abandoning the luxury model in exchange for volume sales.

Dannok also believed the family could get wealthy far beyond their father's wildest dreams while improving worker conditions. Not because he had a soft spot for the workers, but because expansion at the scale he envisioned would require attracting and retaining skilled labor with the kind of expertise he had studied in the mines of Eelan and in the eastern communes.

Mirae thought he was reckless and motivated by greed rather than ethics. But she saw the inkling of a possibility in his plans.

Kels Tanabrekt, the youngest at 34, wanted nothing to do with any of it. He'd worked in the brewery out of family obligation, but his heart was elsewhere. Specifically, with a handsome Kahila bard named Oshavan who lived in the eastern forest provinces, a rebel whom Kels visited whenever he could escape from Borted. Kels proposed selling his share to his siblings and leaving the brewing business forever to go live the free life of a romperi with his lover. His father had forbidden him from openly acknowledging his relationship with Oshavan and scolded him whenever he heard Kels using expressions in the old Eibar spoken in the Kahilabarbakol.

Now his father was dead, and Kels wanted freedom more than he wanted wealth or influence. His siblings thought he was escaping responsibility. He thought they were both trapped by ambition and obsessions.

Catastrophe as Catalyst

For two years after the old man's death, the Tanabrekt siblings fought. Legal disputes over inheritance. Heated family meetings. Competing visions. The brewery operated in a kind of stasis, maintaining production but making no major changes while the family sorted itself out. Then three weeks before the Wildwind Festival, fire broke out in the working-class districts of Borted town south of the river.

No one knows how it started. Maybe a forge left burning overnight. A

cooking fire spreading to timber structures. Some whispered arson, though for what purpose remained unclear. What mattered was that once started, the fire consumed everything in its path. The district was packed tight. Narrow alleys. Wooden buildings sharing walls. Few fire breaks. When flames jumped from building to building, there was no stopping them. It was a disaster.

The Cann of Bordered mobilized every available person to fight the blaze. The Varkaar Arms leapt into action and the towns folk joined in en masse. They created firebreaks by demolishing buildings in the fire's path. They formed bucket chains from the river. They evacuated residents ahead of the raging flames. For three days and nights, the battle continued.

When it finally burned itself out, an entire district was gone. Hundreds of buildings destroyed. Thousands homeless. Miraculously, only seventeen dead. The quick thinking and mass support for the evacuation efforts had saved most. But the displaced had nowhere to go and winter was approaching.

The Tanabrekt workers' quarters, just adjacent to the burned district, had survived. Mirae immediately opened them to refugees, housing dozens of families in spaces designed for individual workers. As Mirae coordinated emergency shelter and Dannok worked with the Cann on relief efforts, something shifted. They stopped fighting each other and started working together. Even Kels, watching his siblings respond to crisis with competence and compassion and seeing the outpouring of admiration for them, had a realization. Maybe he didn't want to abandon them after all.

And as he stared up at the Fatunik sunburst design on the brewery banner flying over their workers' quarters, he had an idea.

Three days after the fire was contained, the Tanabrekt siblings made a joint announcement that shocked Bordered.

The Decision

They would rebuild the entire burned district. Not just replace what was lost, but build something better.

The new construction was the largest renovation effort Bored had ever seen. It featured multi-story stone and timber buildings, fire-resistant and structurally sound. There were generous living spaces for familiar groups and common areas including food halls where residents could share meals. And the neighborhood design was revolutionary: public parks and green spaces with shade trees, plus public exercise areas and training grounds for folks of all ages. Even bolder, at Mirae's insistence they build educational facilities available to all outside of any guild strictures and workshops where residents could practice trades and crafts of multiple kinds.

The pay for brewery workers was raised and rates for housing in the new area was set to be affordable to brewery workers as well as many others. Rents would be set to cover maintenance and provide a modest profit, not to maximize return. The whole concept was a departure. And the cost to complete the entire project would be enormous.

Dannok was well aware that the Tanabrekt fortune couldn't cover it alone, so he simultaneously tapped into the Bored enthusiasm for financial schemes and took a giant risk by taking advanced orders for expanded ale production from clients near and far. Financing was a combination of family investment, with the sibling retaining the majority ownership, plus loans from Bored banks secured against brewery assets and future profits, along with additional grants from the Varkaar Council in exchange for provisioning housing for so many workers.

The siblings formalized their agreement amongst themselves. Mirae would run daily operations, with a focus on workers' welfare, the housing project and production quality. Dannok would handle expansion, distribution, and financial management. Kels would manage community relations. His relationship with Oshavan was made public, causing some scandal, but the biggest shock was yet to come.

Kels revealed a change to the brewery's brand mark from the Fatunik sun-burst symbol to a stylized profile of a bold rabbit-sint surrounded by the words "Bored Ale - The Drink of the Ring" and in smaller text, a motto reading "Brewed Under Oath".

The Brand Change

Adopting a rabbit head as their symbol was extraordinary. The Untamed was already organizing guerrilla attack on the Tagabant outposts. Malavorra was considered a dangerous revolutionary by conservative elements throughout the Saskan Lands. The brand did not clearly declare support for the Untamed or Malavorra. Indeed the slogan and the motto were clear references to the Articles of Bordered and to the main mission of the Varkaar, to serve and protect all the folks of the Saskan Lands and guard travellers on the Ring Road. But to even depict "just a rabbit" as the most visible logo for Bordered Ale was a change in the wind that couldn't be mistaken.

Mirae explained it in public remarks: "Our father built this brewery on the labor of rabbit-sints whom he treated as lesser beings. We reject that hierarchy. The Tanabrekt brewery supports the dignity and rights of all sints. We may not support all the methods of the radicals, but we support their cause. Let our ale carry that message."

Kels made even more inflammatory remarks, tying the new brand to Kahila grievances as well. Dannok worked behind the scenes on two levels; in both cases very, very quietly. First he went to great lengths to reassure the Bordered elite that the family were only looking to improve the position of the Covenant across the Lands, not to stir up trouble. And secondly, he delivered a significant amount of cash to a wide variety of rabbit-sint organizations, without asking questions about their relationship with the Untamed, in the interest of rapidly building up a massively expanded distribution network for the product.

The conservative Fatunik community in Bordered was outraged. Council members who were closer to the Fatunik Authority's views called it inappropriate, even dangerous. Some of the exclusive dining halls and inns who had served the ale for centuries to their elite clientele threatened boycotts.

Then something unexpected happened. The boycotts never materialized. The outrage fizzled out quickly. Because the Tanabrekt siblings did exactly what they had promised, and the results spoke louder than denunciations. More far-sighted conservatives, that type

of Bordered conservative who, even if they believe in the light, also understand why banking power will always win out against the bluster of the Noonday Scribes, they saw something else. They saw a way to turn revolutionaries reaching for pole-axes and surging into the streets, into "revolutionaries" paying for a mug of ale and keeping their rousing songs in the pubs.

A Promise Made Real

The rebuilding took three years. The Tanabrekt siblings hired hundreds of workers. It was the largest employment scheme ever seen in the Covenant lands. They gave preference to those displaced by the fire, employing sint and hum equally, paying fair wages, and maintaining safe conditions. Mirae personally oversaw working conditions. When a foreman was caught shorting rabbit workers' pay, she fired him, denounced him publicly and paid the workers triple the stolen amount from her own pocket.

Dannok negotiated with suppliers and distributors far and wide, secured materials for expansion and modernization of the brewery, managed budgets, and kept the project on schedule despite setbacks. Dannok dramatically expanded brewery production. New fermentation vessels. Additional storage. Enhanced quality control. Distribution contracts with merchants and caravaners across all the provinces, engaging with nearly every known trade networks in the Lands.

Kels worked with Mirae to organize community meetings where displaced families could voice concerns and preferences. He brought Oshavan to Bordered to consult on design principles emphasizing harmony between built and natural environments and together they produce a songbook for brewery workers.

Three years after the fire, the Tanabrekt Housing Complex opened. Six interconnected buildings housing over 200 family groups, featuring the promised amenities, offered at affordable rates. The opening ceremony featured speeches, performances, and of course a great deal of free-flowing Bordered Ale for everyone who attended. It

was the first time most working folk had tasted the legendary drink.

The response was immediate. The ale was exceptional. Smooth, flavorful, with subtle complexity that revealed itself across multiple sips. For many, the fact that it now bore a rabbit-sint image and a Varkaar slogan made it taste even better.

The Drink of the Ring

Dannok's gamble paid off spectacularly. As production expanded and prices dropped, Bordered Ale became accessible to broader markets. It soon started appearing in taverns and inns across the provinces. Merchants ordered barrels for festivals, then entire caravans of the stuff.

The Wildwind Festival in Bordered now featured Bordered Ale as a central attraction. The ale's association with progressive politics ended up enhancing rather than hurting its appeal and, though impossible to measure, the brewing tensions between dissatisfied sints and their bosses throughout the region seemed to be tempered as well. Workers saving up to afford a barrel of Bordered Ale for celebrations felt that they weren't just buying a luxury drink to impress their friends and community; they were making a statement.

The Tanabrekt brewery became one of the largest employers in Bordered and throughout the Covenant. Hundreds of workers in production, distribution, sales, and support functions. All receiving fair wages, working in safe conditions, with opportunities for advancement based on skill rather than species or family connections. The family's wealth grew enormously. But unlike the old days when profits went to ostentatious displays, the Tanabrekt siblings reinvested heavily in their workers and the community while living comfortably, but not extravagantly.

Current Status

Fifty years after the transformation, the Tanabrekt family remains one of the wealthiest in the Saskan Lands. Bordered Ale is consumed in all the provinces, and is associated with quality, celebration, and progressive politics.

The original three siblings have aged into elder leadership. Mirae now at 91 turns still visits the brewery weekly, though day-to-day operations have passed to the next generation. Dannok at 88 remains active in commercial negotiations and expansion planning. Kels, 84, splits time between Bored and the Kahila lands, where he and Oshavan, now 81, are respected elders representing the new more cosmopolitan type of romperi.

The next generation continues the family tradition with modifications of their own. Mirae's daughter runs daily operations with emphasis on environmental sustainability. Dannok's son manages finance and distribution while Kels's adopted Kahila children are involved in community relations and cultural programs.

But success has also created complications.

The Tanabrekt family is enormously wealthy. Loans have long since been paid off. They own the brewery and the housing complex, and have their hands in diversified investments across Bored's complex economy. They're very much part of the elite despite their progressive politics.

During rabbit protests in Bored, Tanabrekt workers, sint and hum alike, often join the demonstrations, with the family's blessing and without penalty. The brewery shuts down during work stoppages in solidarity. This has earned enormous respect from organizing movements while confusing some ideologically conservative elements who still can't understand why wealthy owners would support workers' political activism.

Some radical voices within the rabbit community question whether the Tanabrekt model is a genuine ally in the struggle for liberation or just a gentler, kinder exploitation. Can there be ethical ownership when the fundamental structure remains owners profiting from workers' labor?

Some have openly questioned whether the Tanabrekt's are actively funding the Untamed -- and possibly militant Kahila elements as well. But nothing like that has ever been proved.

The Tanabrekt family doesn't claim to have solved all problems or

abolished all hierarchies. What they claim is that how you wield power matters, that incremental progress is still progress, and that transforming one institution from exploitation to partnership is worth doing even if it doesn't revolutionize the entire system.

The Symbol

The stylized rabbit on every barrel and every bottle of Bordered Ale means different things to different people. To some it's a provocative symbol of dangerous rebellion, though many still drink the ale while grumbling about the packaging. To many rabbit-sints and other non-huum sentients, it's recognition and respect. Being honored by a major huum-owned enterprise carries profound symbolic weight, especially in the Fatunik Dominion.

To workers generally, it represents the possibility that employers might actually care about their wellbeing, that fair treatment isn't just a dream. To the Tanabrekt family, it's a reminder of the commitment they made fifty years ago to a standard they must continue meeting. It is a promise that outlasts any individual family member.

The Festival Connection

The connection to Bordered Wildwind Festival has become central to the brewery's identity. During the annual celebration, the Tanabrekt brewery sponsors public events, provides free ale to festival goers. Within reason. They're progressive, not suicidal about alcohol poisoning. The Brewery's community outreach groups host gatherings that bring together workers, merchants, Varkaar Arms and even Council and Cann members in celebration.

The original Wildwind Festival in the distant Ny Lands runs for two weeks and holds together the wild tribal culture of that region. Bordered's three-day version pales in comparison to the original's chaos and glory, but Bordered's Wildwind has become its own tradition, and the Tanabrekt family has become so associated with the festival that many younger residents assume the brewery invented it.

Naturally, this assumption annoys residents from the Ny Lands who visit Bordered and hear people talking about "Bordered's Wildwind Festival" or the "Bordered Ale Festival" as if it originated here. But Ny

folk also appreciate good ale, so they grumble and drink and eventually forgive the cultural appropriation.

Legacy and Questions

The Tanabrekt transformation is studied, debated, celebrated, and criticized. Progressive elements hold it up as proof that ethical business is possible and profitable. Conservatives grumble that the family abandoned tradition and proper hierarchy. Radicals argue it's a feel-good story that ultimately preserves rather than challenges fundamental inequality. Scholars study it looking for patterns and signs.

The family themselves seem less concerned with being ideologically pure than with running a good brewery, treating workers decently, and continuing to innovate.

Recent developments include experimental brewing with alternative grains to reduce dependence on scarce hops and initiating a partnership with Terpin agricultural researchers on sustainable farming practices. The training programs have expanded, regardless of species or background and the family have begun to invest in worker-owned cooperatives as minority partners, bringing in Mobali and Baranuq and Eelani community leaders to teach Bordali folk how that works. And though they are careful to avoid any appearance of undue meddling in political affairs, they have quietly begun to support candidates for election to the Council who support worker rights and sint equality.

The question that lingers is whether one family, one business, one transformation can actually change systemic problems? Or does the Tanabrekt story ultimately serve to make people feel better about a system that still requires most workers to suffer under employers far less enlightened? The Tanabrekt family tends to provide very diplomatic answers when quizzed: "We can't fix everything, but we can fix what's ours. And maybe we can inspire others to do the same."

Whether that's enough remains contested.

What's indisputable is that when working families across the Saskan Lands gather for celebrations, when they want to mark special

occasions with something beyond water, weak tea, or an ordinary s'lah now they reach for tankards bearing a simple image: a rabbit, looking toward the horizon, reminding everyone who sees it that dignity and justice are worth fighting for.

And the ale itself? Still exceptional. The Tanabrekt family may be many things, but bad brewers has never been among them.

The Time of Fire

The sky above Eelan turned black for three days. Not from clouds, but from the smoke of a fire that burned from the foothills of the Krunkinotto to the edge of the Borda Woods . The wall of flame was fifty kilometers long, fed by something no one had seen before. A substance drawn from deep wells in western Baranuq, transported in secret, ignited in a demonstration of destructive capability that changed the balance of power across the northern Saskan Lands.

They called it the Time of Fire. Fifty years later, travelers still see the scars: blackened stone, skeletal forests, and villages that were never rebuilt.

The Spark

It was autumn, during the Festival of the Full Moons in Eelan Town, when four bodies were discovered in a storage cellar beneath a miners' way house. Tagabant agents, working undercover to gather intelligence on Eelani ore production and trade agreements. Their throats had been cut with precision, their uniforms stripped, their identity papers burned.

The Fatunik Dominion, still based then in the old capital of Juuj, demanded immediate justice. Elder Morefan Beshqau — no relation to the hot springs town that would later bear a similar name —

accused the Eelani leadership of orchestrating the murders. He gave them ten days to surrender the killers.

The Eelani refused. They had no killers to surrender. Their own investigations found no witnesses, no weapons, no motive. The murders had the marks of professional work, but not in the style of any known Eelani work unit. Some whispered about strangers seen at the festival. Pale-faced, long-limbed, speaking in no known dialect, floating above the ground, a mad laugh. Others dismissed this as festival-drunk fantasy.

The Fatunik Authority ordered Tagabant to march on Eelan.

The War

What followed was brutal and grinding. Tagabant forces, flush from recent campaigns against Kahila rebels and Wesshewen barbarians, expected quick submission from what they saw as a fractious community of bumpkin miners and metalworkers. Instead, they found an enemy who knew every tunnel, every pass, every loose stone in the highlands.

Eelani guerrillas fought from mine shafts and mountain redoubts. Dominion forces controlled the valleys but bled for every inch of ever slope. Thousands died on both sides. Entire Tagabant units were ambushed in narrow defiles. Eelani villages were razed when suspected of harboring fighters.

After two turns, the war had ground into stalemate. The Fatunik Dominion held the Ring Road and the lowland approaches to the Eelani highlands. The Eelani held the heights. Neither side could claim victory. Both sides bled resources they could not replace.

Trade throughout the region ground to a halt. The Varkaar Council in Bordered, alarmed at the proximity of the fighting and the disruptions to commerce, sent emissaries to Juuj urging a stand down. Their protests were ignored.

Then came the fire.

The Fire

To this day, no one knows or at least no one is admitting, exactly how the Dominion acquired it. Western Baranuq, Terpin lands, had discovered the combustible liquids seeping from the ground centuries earlier, but they kept knowledge of it close to home, using it for the lights of Kurosol and later to some interesting effects in Terpinol, but never as a commodity for export. And they certainly never proposed it as a weapon.

Somehow. Through bribes, through theft, through intermediaries whose names have never been revealed, barrels of the combustible liquids made their way north. Hundreds of them. Perhaps thousands. The details are both a secret and a crime. What can be certain is that Tagabant engineers secretly constructed a long line of trenches and channels along the western edge of Eelan territory, from the foothills to the forest edge.

On the morning of Third Moon's Rise, they set it alight.

The fire roared. It consumed dry autumn grass, then leaped into the pine forests of the Borda Woods. The smoke was visible all the way to Barból, Borted and Turno. It rose in a black column that blotted out Fatune's light for days. The flames advanced towards Eelani settlements in the western valleys, driven by autumn winds.

Witnesses described a sound like continuous thunder. The air itself seemed to scream. Swarms of Eelani and Bordali refugees fled west and east, carrying children and what possessions they could grab. Many didn't make it. The official death toll from the fire itself was never established. Hundreds at minimum, possibly thousands.

For three days the fire burned. When it finally exhausted its fuel and the winds shifted, an enormous black scar marked the western approach to Eelan. Charred earth. Skeletal trees. Stones split from heat. The threat was unmistakable. The Dominion could do this again. They could burn Eelan to ash.

The Intervention

Faced with annihilation, the Eelani leadership, sent urgent messages to Bordered. They requested formal protection under the Articles of Bordered, that ancient promise to protect all life around the Ring from dangers and oppressors. They did not petition for membership in the Covenant of Varkaar. The Eelani had spent centuries guarding their independence. They sought the protection that would bring the Varkaar's military strength to bear against further threats of aggression from the Fatunik Authority.

The Varkaar Council debated for two days. Then they sent a single message to Elder Morefan Beshqau: any further attacks on Eelan would be considered attacks on Varkaar interests. The Varkaar Arms would be deployed in the defense of Eelan. The Ring Road would be closed to Dominion traffic. Economic ties between Bordered and towns of the Fatunik Dominion, substantial and profitable for centuries, would be severed.

The Elders blinked.

Morefan Beshqau, facing opposition within his own council over the massive expenditure and limited gains of the Eelan campaign, and growing discontent in the Fatunik regions, accepted a negotiated withdrawal. The Tagabant forces pulled back to their pre-war positions. The Eelani remained independent, but now under the explicit protection of their powerful northern neighbor. The Varkaar never loosed a bolt. It was one thing for the Tagabant commanders to confront what they thought of as noisy but weak mountain people. Taking on the full force of the riders of the Varkaar Arms, the vaunted Báhkar, was another matter altogether.

The Aftermath

Fifty years later, the scars remain. The western approach to Eelan is still called the Blacklands. Some vegetation has returned. Scrub growth, hardy grasses, a few pioneer saplings, but the great pines are gone. An aggressive red bougainvillea grew up on the ash that threatens to choke the Ring Road. Old-timers can still point to where

villages stood before the fire took them.

The political scars run even deeper. Eelan accepted Varkaar protection but refused full integration into the Covenant of Varkaar. They still maintain their own governance, their own mining operations, their own trade agreements. The Varkaar Council has no authority over Eelani internal affairs. In practice, this means Eelan benefits from Varkaar military deterrence while remaining aloof from their neighbor's politics.

This arrangement works when interests align. When they don't, as in recent years, with Borted's cautious, measured response to the provocations of the New Fatunik Authority, then the Eelani chafe. They remember who stood with them when the fires burned and remain grateful. They also recall how many days it took to respond to their request and remain wary of the depth of commitment that the Báhkar have to Eelan.

The quiet leading councils of Terpinol and Baranuq remain horrified at how their combustibles were weaponized and still refuse to discuss the topic. A few Byenung scholars have published impassioned treatises condemning the perversion of natural philosophy for martial devastation. These treatises are popular in the hilltop taverns of Eelan, where they're read aloud during the annual Remembrance of the Flames events, but are not discussed elsewhere.

And in Beshqauhoek, the Grand Tagabant Tonedor Rumpet likes to study the maps and reports from that war. Not for the tactical lessons, but for the strategic ones. The lesson he drew was simple. The Dominion's reach exceeds what anyone thought possible at the time; their mistake was backing down. In his mind, the suppression of the Kahila proved his point. And he feels certain that the tools exist to reclaim what he sees as the Greater Dominion.

All that's required is the will to use them.

Where the Mountains Remember Fire

Stand at the base of the Krunkinotto foothills and look up toward Eelan Town. You won't see much. The settlements hide in the folds of terrain, built into cliff faces, tucked behind ridge lines. What you will hear, if the wind is right, is the whistling.

Three notes, rising. Repeated from peak to peak. You've been spotted. They know you're coming. By the time you reach the first mining camp, everyone within fifty kilometers knows. Outsider approaching, single traveler, no visible weapons, moving slowly up the eastern path.

Welcome to Eelan Province. The hills have eyes, the rocks have ears, and the miners have long memories.

They remember the Time of Fire. They remember asking Bordered for help and waiting for days while their people burned. They remember the protection agreement from the Cann coming at the last moment, just enough to make the Dominion back down, never enough to make them feel truly safe.

They remember who stands with them but calculated the costs before doing so.

And now, as Grand Tagabant Tonedor Rumpet sharpens his knives and Bordered issues diplomatic protests when their own Báhkar are burned at the stake, the Eelani are drawing conclusions. They're looking west toward High Weir, toward the mysterious Empafarasi who don't talk much about friendship but whose actions in Ríkila suggest they understand what protection actually means.

The Varkaar are losing Eelan. Not through conquest or dramatic rupture, but through the quiet recognition that protection without commitment is just a polite form of abandonment. The miners know what's coming. The stones remember. The fire taught them. And nobody, nobody, fucks with the miners of Eelan.

What Makes Eelan Unique

Eelan isn't like other provinces. It never has been.

Eelan occupies the most naturally defensible terrain in the Saskan Lands, possibly barring High Weir. Nestled in the western approaches to the Krunkinotto Mountains, the province is a maze of valleys, ridges, cliff faces, and passes that only locals can navigate efficiently.

The elevation ranges from 800 to 2,400 meters. The valleys are narrow, the slopes are steep, and the paths are treacherous if you don't know them. An invading force would have to climb, crawl, and struggle for every kilometer while defenders held high ground and rained hell down from above. The Tagabant learned this the hard way during the Time of Fire. They held the lowland approaches. They never took the mountains.

Natural springs and underground aquifers provide abundant water. The mountains contain seemingly inexhaustible mineral deposits. Timber from lower slopes provides building materials. Game animals of the non-sentient variety supplement food supplies. Eelan could survive isolation better than almost anywhere else in the Saskan Lands. This shapes everything about Eelani culture. They don't need you nearly as much as you need them.

Eelan mines produce the vast majority, estimated 70-80%, of workable iron ore in the Saskan Lands. Without it, weapons manufacturing, tool production, and construction across the provinces would collapse. They are major suppliers of copper and tin, essential for bronze work though less critical than iron. Still, Eelan's copper is higher quality than Liganalupán's and their tin deposits are unmatched. Coal is Eelan's secret. It is the fuel that powers forges across the north and Eelan has and uses much more of it than they let on. Eelan coal burns hotter and cleaner than any alternative. As their secret steam engine experiments advance, coal-fired plants will become even more strategically critical.

Eelan also mines specialized ores used in advanced metallurgy, some with properties not fully understood. These are traded even more cautiously than coal and only to trusted parties. Beyond the, literally,

mountains of raw materials, Eelan workshops produce many of the finest metal goods in the Saskan Lands. Tools that hold edges longer. Mechanisms that function reliably. Alloys with properties that other smiths can't replicate. The economic equation is simple: the Saskan Lands need Eelan far more than Eelan needs the Saskan Lands.

Borded's banks and markets mean nothing if you have no metal. The Fatunik Dominion's military power would collapse without Eelani steel. The Varkaar's protection of Eelan, as many in the mountainous province see it, is worth less than the resources it supposedly protects. The Eelani have always understood this. They knew from the beginning that hitching their wagon to the Covenant was a tricky proposition. What's changing is their willingness to use that leverage.

The Eelani are tough. Not in a performative, boastful way, but with the quiet competence of people who work in conditions that would kill softer populations. They spend lives underground in mines where a single mistake means being crushed by falling rock. They work forges where metal temperatures fluctuate between merely scorching and instantly lethal. They haul loads up mountain paths where losing footing means falling hundreds of meters.

This creates a culture that values competence above all else. Talk is cheap. What matters is whether you can do the work. Eelani have little patience for rhetoric, posturing, or credentials that don't reflect actual skill. They are deeply committed to collective responsibility. Mining is inherently cooperative. One person's mistake endangers everyone. This breeds a deeply communal culture where individual glory matters less than team success.

Technical innovation and egalitarianism are in the blood of every Eelani. When your life depends on tools and techniques working reliably, you become obsessive about improvement. Eelani constantly experiment, refine, and perfect their methods. And underground, appearances matter for very little and everyone bleeds the same color when the rock falls. Surface hierarchies based on birth or species matter less than who you trust with your life in the dark.

All of this adds up to a fiercely independent sense of autonomy.

They've survived for centuries without needing external authority, without the Book of the Fatuniks, the Articles of the Varkaar, or even the lofty principles the Dauni Vakasaqua or the Night Hall. They organize themselves. They solve their own problems. And that's that. They don't want rulers, protectors, or anyone telling them how to live.

The Eelani personality can be off-putting to outsiders. They're blunt, impatient with social niceties, and skeptical of anyone claiming authority they haven't earned. But if you prove yourself. If you show competence, demonstrate integrity, and work well alongside them. Then you're in. And they're loyal to you unto death. And expect the same from you.

Cross them, though, and you'll learn why the stones remember isn't just a saying.

Syndicalism That Actually Works

Eelan has no government in the traditional sense. No lord, no council of elders, no elected representatives. But they are far from being the kind of free-for-all whirlwind found in places like the Ny Lands or Arq. What they have is more radical and much more functional.

Every mine, every forge, every workshop operates as a self-governing collective. Workers elect shift coordinators, safety officers, and representatives to higher assemblies. Terms are short, usually six months to a year. Recall is easy if someone proves incompetent or abuses position. Decisions about work conditions, safety protocols, production targets, and resource allocation are made collectively by those doing the work. Not by distant managers or owners. By the miners themselves.

This might sound like chaos but in practice, it's remarkably efficient. People who do the work know what they need. They understand the trade-offs. They make decisions quickly because they live with consequences directly.

Mining is mining, but there are specialties: ore extraction, timber supports, ventilation, explosives, transport, processing, refining, and

more. Each specialty maintains a craft assembly coordinating across multiple workplaces to set technical standards and training requirements and coordinate resource sharing between workplaces, mediate disputes between work teams, plan long-term development and infrastructure and collaborate with other assemblies on complex projects.

Representatives to craft assemblies are elected from workplace assemblies. They serve while they have confidence of their workplaces. Lose that confidence, you're recalled and replaced.

The highest level of organization coordinates across all crafts and workplaces and handles province-wide concerns: defense, relations with outsiders, major infrastructure projects, emergency response.

The Provincial Assembly meets monthly in Eelan Town. It includes representatives from each craft assembly, who are rotated quarterly, plus representatives from geographic regions such as the mountain north, valley settlements, and the eastern approaches, themselves elected by the workplace assemblies in their region. In addition, temporary delegates are brought in for specific issues requiring expertise. The Provincial Assembly has been granted emergency powers during crises, but always with sunset clauses and recall procedures in place. It has no permanent leadership. Facilitators rotate. No one accumulates power across time. Decisions require consensus or supermajority depending on urgency and scope.

From the outside, this interlocking, overlapping web of bottom-up assemblies looks impossibly cumbersome. How can you govern by consensus? How can anything get done when everyone has a voice? The answer is that it works because Eelani culture supports it. They've internalized, over many centuries of development, the values and practices that make decentralized organization function.

Technical competence is highly respected. When engineers say a mine shaft needs reinforcement, people listen because engineers know mines. Authority comes from expertise, not position. And problems are solved where they occur. Workplace assemblies handle most issues directly. Only genuinely complex problems that affect multiple workplaces get elevated to higher levels. There is no room left for fiefdoms to develop and on top of that, transparency is default. All

assembly meetings at every level are open. Records are public and financial accounting, along with all other technical detail, is detailed and accessible. Corruption and vanity are difficult when everyone can see everything.

There is a social aspect to it as well. Participation is expected. Eelani life is intensely social. Everyone attends their workplace assembly. Everyone votes. Everyone takes turns in coordination roles. And everyone tends to eat together, party together and share their lives in a fairly intimate manner, given the close quarters in which most Eelani live and work. It's not optional; it's how community functions. At the same time, and for much the same reasons, dissent is protected. Speaking against majority opinion doesn't make you a traitor. It makes you someone with concerns that need addressing. The culture values thoughtful disagreement. Eelani folks live too much on top of each other to allow disagreements to develop into anti-social behavior or long-term feuds.

Could this system scale to govern the entire Covenant of Varkaar? Or be exported to other provinces. It is a question that some scholars in Terpinol and at the Night Hall have looked into. Their tentative conclusion: probably not. The specific conditions that make it work in Eelan; its small population, homogeneous work culture, high technical competence, and the traumatic history of the Eelani-Fatunik War don't exist elsewhere.

But in Eelan it works beautifully. The Eelani built something extraordinary and they know it. They're not interested in compromising it to fit into someone else's political structure. And their economic and political system is not their only innovation.

When Mountains Speak

The Eelani developed a sophisticated acoustic communication system that makes information travel at speeds that shock outsiders. In mountain terrain, sound carries strangely. Valleys create echoes. Wind distorts. But with training and technique, specific sounds can travel kilometers with remarkable clarity.

Eelani children master much of the system by age five. This starts with basic whistles conveying simple messages like danger, all clear, help needed, and stranger approaching. As they reach age ten, they have begun to master more complex whistles that can communicate numbers, directions, and specific warnings like fire, collapse, or flooding. Those who are responsible for communications between villages go on to learn Eelani yodelling, in which longer messages with tonal variations encode meaning. A skilled yodeller can transmit across three kilometers of some mountain valleys. Finally, Eelani trackers and soldiers also make animal calls that mimic local wildlife for covert communication. It sounds entirely natural to outsiders, while conveying information to trained listeners.

An Eelani on a high ridge can signal to the next peak. That person relays to another peak. Within fifteen minutes, a message crosses twenty kilometers. Within an hour, the entire province knows. The Eelani see you, whistle to the next ridge, and soon everyone knows you're coming, what you look like, and whether you appear to be threatening.

The whistling, yodelling and animal call systems can handle urgent warnings of immediate threats, accidents, or alerts; simple coordination regarding work crew locations and resource needs; and social communication -- someone's having a baby, a festival is planned at a specific village on a specific date. While the more complex forms can also handle a certain level of increased complexity, they can't handle complex technical information, detailed plans or instructions, subtle nuances and subtleties or messages intended for specific individuals only.

For those needs, couriers are essential. Both the Ring Runners and the Rabbit Messenger Service (RMS) operate in Eelan, although the Ring Runners do so a bit nervously, knowing that their official status doesn't guarantee a warm welcome. The miners have their own courier services as well. The combination of instant basic communication via whistles and detailed information via couriers makes Eelan's information network among the fastest in the Saskan Lands despite its remote location.

The whistle system also serves rapid defense. Every outsider entering

Eelan territory is tracked acoustically. Invading forces would find themselves fighting while surrounded by constant communication they can't intercept or interpret. During the Time of Fire, Tagabant commanders were unnerved by constant whistling and yodelling from the mountains. They knew they were being watched, discussed, and coordinated against. They couldn't stop it or decode it.

The psychological effect was significant. Eelani defenders anticipated every move, appeared where needed and vanished when threatened. The communication system contributed to the Beshquahoeck's eventual decision that conquering Eelan wasn't worth the cost.

The plain fact is that Eelani technical capability surpasses even the Mobali shipwrights, Terpin scholars, and Byenung engineers. The Eelan mines are marvels of engineering. They have ventilation systems with elaborate networks of shafts and fans, some wind-powered, some manually operated, some experimental steam-driven, that keep deep mines breathable. Sophisticated timber and metal frameworks prevent the deep mines from collapsing. Eelani engineers calculate load distributions and failure points with precision that requires a sophisticated understanding of mathematics. They have developed practical mathematics through experience.

They are masters of both explosives and water management. Pump systems remove water from deep mines, using hydraulic principles and, increasingly, early versions of steam engines. The carefully controlled use of black powder and experimental compounds for excavation is one of their closest-held techniques. Eelani blasting techniques are art and science combined. To date, these skills have never been deployed for martial purposes, and they are not shared with outsiders.

The Eelani have developed lift systems too. Mechanisms for moving ore, equipment, and people run vertically through mine shafts using counterweighted platforms, mechanical advantage systems, and prototype steam-powered lifts.

Eelani metalworkers produce alloys and treatments that others can't replicate. This includes high-carbon steel that is harder and more durable than standard steel, holding edges longer while remaining

flexible enough not to shatter and specialized bronze alloys with unusual properties like corrosion resistance, specific melting points, and acoustic characteristics much valued by musicians all over the Lands.

The Eelani surface treatments use techniques that make metal more resistant to rust, wear, or extreme temperatures and they have mastered precision casting methods for creating complex metal parts with tolerances measured in fractions of millimeters.

They achieve this partly through access to better raw materials, partly through accumulated knowledge passed down and refined through generations and partly through systematic experimentation. But also, as with explosives, steam and hydraulics, they don't share their most important techniques. Eelani metallurgy remains largely secret, very much hidden deep underground. They'll sell finished products but they do not reveal manufacturing methods.

The most revolutionary development is likely to be the fact that Eelani engineers are experimenting with building steam engines. To their chagrin, it is also their most-leaked advanced technology. The technology exists elsewhere in nascent form. Terpin scholars understand the theoretical principles. The Empafarasi possess far more advanced technology but they keep their technology even more carefully hidden than the Eelani. But the Eelani are the first in the Saskan Lands to develop practical, working steam engines for mining and industrial applications.

Current achievements include prototype steam pumps removing water from deep mines and powering ventilation fans, experimental small locomotives for moving ore within large mining complexes and prototype stationary engines powering various types of machinery. This terrifies some and excites others. The Empafarasi are watching the Eelan with mixed degrees of admiration and alarm. The Terpins worry about weaponization. The Dominion's scribes argue about how heretical the technology is, and the Tagabant officials and merchant class wring their hands over not being able to acquire it.

The Eelani pursue steam power for practical reasons. It solves problems. Mines need water removed. Heavy loads need moving.

Manual labor is limited. Steam engines are tools, nothing more.

But tools change worlds. Outsiders ask why won't Eelan share their innovations and the Eelani answer, bluntly: "Because you'll use it against us." During the Time of Fire, Dominion forces used weapons and techniques they learned from Eelani traders and materials taken from the Settan Lands. After the war, recovered equipment showed that Tagabant engineers had stolen, studied and copied Eelani designs on steam combustion. The lesson was clear. Sharing technology will arm potential enemies for future conflicts.

The Eelani restrictions frustrates Terpin and Byenung scholars who believe knowledge should be shared. It angers Varkaar authorities who feel entitled to access in exchange for the protection they offer. It makes Mobali engineers a bit jealous. No one knows for sure how the Empafarasi feel about it, but you can be sure they're paying attention. The Eelani don't care. They learned that survival means controlling what advantages you have.

Strangers asking detailed questions about mines, techniques, or facility locations, or even asking exceedingly naive questions about festivals, get friendly but uninformative answers and extra surveillance. Aggressive questioning gets you escorted to the border. Attempting to actually spy on Eelani operations? Good luck. Eelani workers recognize outsiders instantly. On top of the social cohesion, the facilities themselves are designed to limit sight-lines. Critical areas are underground or behind multiple checkpoints. Guard rotations are unpredictable. On top of everything else, the Eelani dialect of Eibar is one of the most difficult for non-native-speakers to master.

Many have attempted to infiltrate Eelan's mines. Success rate approaches zero. Security is culturally embedded. Every Eelani understands that their safety depends on collective awareness. Children learn that if you see strangers, whistle. If someone asks suspicious questions, report. If equipment goes missing, investigate immediately. This isn't paranoia. It's learned caution from people who remember being attacked and almost wiped out and know it can happen again.

The result is a province where everyone participates in security

without it feeling oppressive to insiders. To outsiders, it can be unsettling. You're always watched. Conversations are overheard and assessed. Your presence is known to people you never see. Eelani don't see this as surveillance state. They see it as community looking out for itself.

Walk certain valleys in western Eelan and you'll still see the burns. Two hundred and fifty years after the Time of Fire, the landscape remembers. Blackened rock. Soil that won't sustain growth. Ruins of villages that were never rebuilt. The Eelani don't discuss the fire with outsiders. They don't describe the stories handed down of what it was like to watch enormous walls of flame advancing towards you, to flee with children and possessions, to return finding homes gone and neighbors dead.

But like the folks of the Borda Woods on the other side of the wall of flame, they remember. Every Eelani can name dozens of names of folks lost in the fires. Every child knows the stories. A memorial in Eelan Town lists the names. Tens of thousands of them. The dead, the missing, those who survived but were broken by what they witnessed.

The Time of Fire crystallized certain truths for the Eelani. Protection promised isn't protection delivered. Bordered finally said they'd defend Eelan. The attacks kept coming while they debated and more folks died. The protection materialized only when the computation was that it would be politically and economically advantageous for Bordered, not when it was necessary for Eelan.

Only self-reliance is reliable. Eelan survived not through Varkaar intervention but through their own resistance, their knowledge of terrain, their willingness to fight. External help may come. They are grateful that the Varkaar finally spoke up, but counting on anyone other than yourself is foolish. Technical superiority is survival. For the years of fighting, the Tagabant could not conquer Eelan, could barely take an inch, because Eelani weapons, fortifications, and tactical innovations made conquest too costly. Being technically ahead isn't luxury; it's a survival necessity.

Sharing is vulnerability. The fire was ignited using strange liquids from western Baranuq, resources that the Terpins have always intended for peaceful use, resources that were weaponized. The ability

to use the Baranuq material to create the huge combustible explosions had to have come from stolen Eelani designs. Every innovation shared is a weapon given to potential enemies.

Borded didn't rush to defend Eelan from altruism or solidarity. They acted when they determined that losing Eelan to Fatunik control threatened their economic interests. The Eelani were protected not as valued partners but as strategic resources.

These lessons have shaped everything. The secrecy. The self-governance. The reluctance to fully integrate with the Covenant of Varkaar. The growing interest in Empafarasi alternatives.

The fire taught them. The stones remember.

If the Varkaar won't act decisively when their own elite warriors are publicly murdered, what will they do when Tagabant forces once again approach Eelan? Deliberate for days? Issue more protests? Calculate whether defending miners is worth disrupting trade relationships? The answer seems more clear than ever. We can expect the Varkaar to protect Eelan exactly as much as it serves Borded's interests, and not a moment sooner.

The Empafarasi of High Weir are aloof and keep their true capabilities hidden. They don't advertise protection. They don't seek alliances. But the Eelani, whose realm is closer to Omoyano than anyone else's, have noticed things. When threats approach Empafarasi borders, their responses are immediate and overwhelming. No deliberation. No hesitation. Just action. And in those quick, decisive, limited interactions, the Beqawar demonstrate technical knowledge far beyond anyone else's. They're not just sophisticated; they're operating on different level entirely.

The Eelani have also seen that the Empafarasi don't exploit relationships. They trade fairly, when they trade at all, respect autonomy, and don't pressure partners into dependence. And unlike Borded, which claims to value privacy while maintaining a vast intelligence network sticking its nose into everyone's business, the Empafarasi keep quiet and if they are watching you, you'd never know it. The Eelani appreciate the reciprocal respect for a high level

of operational security.

The Empafarasi don't promise protection to anyone. As far as anyone can tell, they don't negotiate and they don't make deals. But territories near their borders are never attacked. Threats simply... don't materialize. This is protection without obligation, security without subordination. Over the past thirty years, Eelan-Empafarasi contact has increased with a few rare trade delegations and technical consultations. When Maken operatives have been spotted near Eelan, the Beqawar alerted the Eelani guards and worked with them to neutralize the threat. A few Eelani have been invited for cultural exchange to Omoyano and been granted tours of the Mistral Tower.

Nothing is formalized. No treaties signed. No formal negotiations. Certainly no official alliance declared. But everyone understands what's happening. Eelan is repositioning. Covering its bets. Slowly, deliberately, they're building relationships that might replace their dependency on Varkaar protection.

The Varkaar Council watches nervously. They issue concerned statements. They send delegations offering reassurances. They propose deeper integration, better terms, guaranteed support. The Eelani listen politely. They know words are just wind. Actions matter. And Borted's actions say they'll protect Eelan when convenient, support them when profitable, and calculate costs when threats emerge. The Empafarasi don't make promises. But they also don't let threats materialize near their interests. If Eelan becomes an Empafarasi interest, threats won't materialize. That's the calculation the Eelani are making.

If Eelan does fully shift allegiance to High Weir, the implications are significant. Borted could lose access to critical resources. The Covenant of Varkaar's metal supply becomes dependent on Empafarasi mediation. The western arc of the Ring Road could become harder to defend. Eelan as hostile or neutral territory rather than protected ally changes certain dynamics. And if Eelan can leave Varkaar protection successfully, why can't Liganalupán? Oknott? Why can't Sallofól? The confederation's coherence depends on provinces believing they benefit from unity behind Borted's leadership.

The Eelani sing. Constantly. Work songs, mourning songs, celebration songs, ridiculous songs about accidents and mishaps and the particular absurdity of life underground.

The songs help to coordinate group efforts like timing of pulls on ropes or synchronizing hammer strikes. They maintain morale in dangerous conditions, build community and even preserve technical knowledge through procedures encoded in verse.

The most famous Eelani song, a slightly rowdy call-and-response barn-burner known across the Saskan Lands, begins:

"Nobody fucks with the miners of Eelan!
We dig deep, we stand tall,
When the mountain calls, we answer, we answer -- all!
When the fire came, we held the line,
Now we're stronger, and the stone, the stone -- is mine."

The last responses, " -- all" and "-- is mine" is always sung by a single voice.

The song continues for twenty-three verses, getting progressively more defiant, crude, and hilarious. Versions exist in all the languages. It's sung at Wildwind Festivals, in Bordered taverns, anywhere people want to invoke Eelani toughness. It is banned throughout the Fatunik provinces, where it is still popular. The Eelani themselves sing it with pride and ironic self-awareness. Yes, they're tough. Yes, they survived fire. Yes, they're bragging. And yes, every word is true.

Mining kills people. Cave-ins, gas pockets, equipment failures, and countless other hazards make Eelani funerals unfortunately regular. When someone dies in the mines, their body is recovered if possible and the funeral involves community gatherings, songs, cremation and mixing ashes into a small metal pour for memorial items. The deceased's name is added to memorial walls. No Eelani life is ever "lost". The stones remember. Life continues, but memory endures.

The Eelani have a saying: "The stone remembers longer than we live, but we live long enough to matter."

Eelan stands at a crossroads.

They've built something extraordinary: a technically advanced, genuinely egalitarian society that functions without traditional hierarchy. They've survived assault and held their independence. They've maintained security while avoiding paranoid authoritarianism. And they have been doing so for centuries.

The miners also say: "Sing loud enough and the mountain joins you."

They sing about digging deep and standing tall. About fire survived and lessons learned. About solidarity, competence, and the particular satisfaction of doing difficult work well. They sing knowing that voices carry in mountains, that sound echoes and amplifies, that singing together is how they coordinate, mourn, celebrate, and remember. The song of Eelan is defiant and joyful and clear. It's mourning and pride. It's the sound of people who survived attempt to break them and emerged stronger.

"Nobody fucks with the miners of Eelan!"

Not anymore. Not ever again. The stones remember. The fire taught them. And the mountains echo with their singing.